REVELATION

The book of Revelation is unique in the NT. It belongs to a genre known as 'apocalyptic', from the Greek word meaning 'revelation'. Apocalyptic literature is characterized by visions that present the past and the future of heaven and earth in light of the present. Apocalyptic biblical literature describes God's plan in history in visions and symbols in which the ultimate destruction of evil and the triumph of good are inevitable. Such books were often written to encourage God's people when they were undergoing suffering or persecution and were anxious about the present and the future. The seer of these visions was frequently guided by a heavenly being who often interpreted the symbolic meaning of the visions.

Apocalypses usually have a narrative or dramatic structure. Daniel is the best known apocalyptic book in the OT, but other passages of the Bible also have apocalyptic features (for example, Isa 24–27; Ezek 1; 40–48; Zech 9–14; and the 'little apocalypses' of Matt 24; Mark 13; Luke 21). There were also non-biblical Jewish apocalyptic books, such as the book of Enoch and some of the Dead Sea Scrolls, written during NT times.

Writers of apocalypses typically used symbols and coded language to disguise what they were really saying from those who were persecuting them. The codes in Revelation were so effective that few people today agree on exactly what John meant. Some think that many of the predictions in Revelation have not yet been fulfilled. They say that John was writing about events that will come to pass in our own time. Taking that view means that John's writing would have had very little relevance for the people of his time. Others explain Revelation in terms of the first-century Christian church, concluding that many of the events described in it took place during the Roman Empire. John was telling the believers of his day that what was happening to them was a necessary part of the divine plan. Still others find references to the ongoing conflict of evil and good throughout human history—a conflict that will continue until Satan has been finally cast into the lake of fire and the people of God enter the new Jerusalem.

Symbolism in Revelation

Revelation is not only written in symbolic language, but it also presents its message in pictures and images. This approach can sometimes be difficult to understand, especially for Western people, who tend to think in abstract terms. It is more familiar to Africans and people in Near Eastern cultures, who are used to expressing themselves in proverbial or concrete language.

Numbers play an important role in Revelation, but commentators disagree about whether particular numbers should be interpreted literally or symbolically. For example, the number seven (seven churches, seven trumpets, seven seals, seven bowls) represents wholeness. John writes to seven literal churches, but at the same time he is addressing the whole church. The number four represents earthly things (four corners of the earth, four winds, four creatures). The number twelve (twelve elders, twelve gates to the holy city) represents both the twelve tribes of the physical Israel in the OT and the twelve apostles, upon whose teaching the church was founded. The number one thousand may symbolize an immense number, and represent something very great, but not necessarily anything numerically precise.

Revelation also includes symbolic images: lampstands, olive trees, stars, horsemen, great cities and a red seven-headed ten-horned dragon all feature in the book. John is merely human, and often when reading Revelation, we feel that he is describing things that lie beyond the power of human language to convey, which is why his images and pictures are often difficult to understand. Once you have come to terms with the author's technique of using visions, imagery and symbolism, which are not commonly used elsewhere in the NT, you will probably have a better grasp of what God wanted the recipients of Revelation to know and do.

Two Extremes to Avoid

Readers are tempted to respond to Revelation in one of two ways. Some find the book so perplexing and weird that they can see no reason to read it and try to understand its message. How can anyone be sure of its meaning? Others fall prey to the opposite danger. They pore over Revelation and conclude that they have discovered the secret explanation of each obscure detail. To the latter group, it may be humbling to learn that every generation since the first century has come up with different interpretations of the meaning and prophecies of Revelation.

Authorship

Both at the beginning and at the end of the book, the author identifies himself as John (1:1, 4, 9; 22:8) and his work as a prophecy (1:3; 22:6–10, 18–19). Widespread testimony attributes the book to the apostle John, who wrote the Gospel of John and the three Letters of John. It must be admitted that this is problematic because the language and grammatical style of this book are p 1570 somewhat different from that in the other books. Yet these differences may be explained in terms of the very different subject matter of this book. Some images, literary forms, symbolism and the liturgical framework in Revelation are indeed similar to the ones found in the other Johannine books. The placement of the purpose statement at the end of the book also matches John's style (22:6–20; see John 20:30–31; 1 John 5:12–13).

Regardless of whether the author was the Apostle John or some other believer named John, Revelation breathes the spirit of the Lord of life, its author's strong faith, and the triumphant march to victory of God's people in the eventual fulfilment of his saving purpose for mankind.

Occasion and Date

John presents himself as one of the sufferers in a great crisis that had befallen the early church. For nearly the first fifty years of its existence, Christianity enjoyed peace in the Roman world. But eventually emperor worship, which had originally been introduced as a political and religious device to unite the many peoples Rome had conquered, was declared the official religion. Any refusal to worship the emperor drew persecution or death. Because Christians could not worship the Roman emperor and remain true to their Lord, they were persecuted by the political authorities. This persecution lies in the background of Revelation. However, the book does not seem to include any specific reference to Nero's persecution of Christians after the great fire of Rome in AD 64, which suggests that it was written between the reign of Nero (AD 54–68) and that of Domitian (AD 81–96).

Purpose

The purpose of Revelation is stated in 22:6–20. It is to encourage Christians of all times to remain faithful until the end, even if it means martyrdom, since they will also be raised from the dead at the second coming of Christ.

The focus on Jesus Christ's triumph over death through his glorious resurrection means that Revelation is a book that has far more to say about the exercise of power than about the manifestation of divine love. Divine power is demonstrated throughout the book, even in the vindication of the Lamb who was a victim. It is that power of unmasking everything that runs like a thread throughout the vision.

Revelation as a Drama

Revelation is presented as both a letter and a drama. It opens and closes like any other letter of that time. What lies in-between is a drama depicting the events that will lead to the ultimate doom of evil and the ushering in of the eternal 'new Jerusalem'.

Viewing the book as a drama arranged into acts and scenes will help you unpack and understand this difficult book. The suggested outline divides the book into seven acts or visions, each with seven scenes. Some acts have interludes and stage settings. It is best to read Revelation one act at a time, rather than all at once.

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COMMENTARY

1:1–6 Introduction

Revelation, like every other book in the Bible, was written for a specific group of people with specific needs. Evidently, the writer originally intended his message to be read aloud in the various local churches to which it was addressed (1:3). It can thus be described as a circular letter.

1:1–3 Title

In ancient times, books were written on sheets of parchment or papyrus, which were sewn together at the sides. These sheets were then rolled up to form a scroll. About AD 150 or a little earlier, the codex, which was shaped like a modern book, made its first appearance. At that time, the title that had previously been on a label attached to the outside of the scroll was transferred to the inside first page as a 'title page'. This, it seems, is what produced the opening words found in Revelation 1:1–3.

Just as the Gospel of John (John 1:1–18) and the First Epistle of John (1 John 1:1–4) begin by announcing that Jesus Christ is central to what is contained in those books, so the book of Revelation starts with the announcement *The revelation of Jesus Christ* (**1:1a**). Christ is in the midst of his suffering people and has been involved in human history from the beginning. Though Christ himself is God, he is also the 'mediator between God and men' (1 Tim 2:5). As such, he receives instructions from the Father about what *to show his servants* (**1:1b**). Jesus, in turn, *made it known by sending his angel to his servant John* (**1:1d**). The mediation of an *angel* is in keeping with the visions of OT apocalyptic writers (Ezek 8; Dan 10). In Revelation, as well as communicating God's message, angels worship God the Father and the Lamb (God the Son) and execute God's judgments on the earth whenever necessary. Angels are referred to about sixty-seven times in the book of Revelation.

p 1572 John is a witness *who testifies to everything he saw* (**1:2**). The main purpose of the revelation he was given was to show God's servants *what must soon take place* (**1:1c**). Historical books like the Pentateuch and the Gospels give us an account of things that have already taken place, whereas apocalyptic writings like Revelation give us an account of present and past events in light of the future. As we read through Revelation, we find that some of these future events are not shown in the clearest light in which God could have set them, but in a light such as he saw most fit and that would best serve his wise and holy purposes.

The blessing in **1:3** is the first of seven contained in the book (14:13; 16:15; 19:9; 20:6; 22:7, 14). It declares the blessedness of one who reads the book or letter of Revelation to a congregation and of those who hear it and take its message to heart. *The one who reads* reflects the early form of worship where a reader would read the Scriptures aloud on the Lord's Day (1:3; 1 Tim 4:13). At that time, only the reader had a copy of the letter or of a particular OT book. Individual possession of Bibles is a very recent privilege. *Those who hear* were the people of the congregations (1:4, 11), who were to hear the written prophecy read. *Prophecy* involves not only future events but also ethical and spiritual exhortations and warnings (Rev 2–3; Isa 1:1–20; Jer 23:1–40). In a sense, it is equivalent to modern exposition of the written word of God.

The reading would also include interpretation to help people understand the written word (Neh 8:8; Mark 4:1–20). Such reading has an impact on people (Heb 4:12; Acts 2:37; 7:54; 10:44).

Therefore, any person called by God to public ministry should reverently and thoroughly prepare himself or herself. It is sad to notice that many a public reader of the Scriptures does not familiarize himself or herself adequately with the text before reading in front of a congregation. A divine exhortation for each public reader and preacher of the scriptures is: 'Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a workman who does not need to be ashamed, and who correctly handles the word of truth' (2 Tim 2:15).

1:4–6 Greetings

Revelation begins and ends like a typical first-century letter. It opens with the commonly used formula in which a greeting contained three parts: Personal greetings: *John, to the seven churches in Asia* (**1:4a**); a blessing: *Grace and peace …* (**1:4b–5a**); and 'a doxology' or prayer: *To him who loves … Amen* (**1:5b–6**).

The greetings distinguish this book from all other Jewish apocalyptic works. John writes to actual, historical churches, addressing them in the same way as other NT epistles do. The churches mentioned in chapters 2 and 3 were all in *Asia* (1:4a), which is not the modern continent of Asia but the Roman province of Asia Minor, in the western part of present-day Turkey.

Like Paul, John combines a Greek greeting ('grace') and a Hebrew greeting ('peace') in the blessing at the opening of this letter (1:4b; see also Rom 1:7; 1 Cor 1:3; 2 Cor 1:2). By 'grace', the Greeks meant something like 'love functioning under adverse conditions.' The noun is derived from a Greek verb that means 'to cheer up'. So what John is saying is this: 'Cheer up because God is in control in spite of the adverse circumstances created by human rebellion'. The standard Hebrew greeting *shalom* or *salaam* literally means 'peace', but it is often used as a synonym for salvation.

The form of the blessing makes it clear that the Trinity is the source of *grace and peace.* John first mentions God the Father, *him who is, and was, and who is to come*, followed by the Holy Spirit, referred to here as *seven spirits.* He mentions Jesus Christ after the Holy Spirit because the following verses and chapters will deal with the person, presence and power of the risen Jesus Christ, God the Son.

The doxology refers to several elements that will be found later in the drama: *freed us … his blood … made us to be a kingdom and priests.* This is the language of the sacrificial system of the OT temple. It is good to keep in mind that the teachings of this letter are presented against a background heavily influenced by the OT.

1:7–8 Dramatic Prologue: The Herald

One key to understanding an author's purpose is grasping the literary structure of what he has written. If Revelation is read as a drama that unfolds the history of human suffering, the embodiment and manifestation of evil, and the ultimate triumph of the Lamb and believers, its message will be easier to grasp. The author uses this literary device as a way of presenting his living message in a telling way. His theme can be understood as an account of the working out of God's plan in human affairs, and the consummation of human history with the return and eternal reign of Christ.

The drama opens with the voices of two figures from behind the curtain, so to speak, who announce their parts. One is a herald or a messenger; and the other is the Lord God himself. This is a cosmic stage and the action is related to God's work in the world. The herald is announcing the motif of the play or drama—'History's most important person is about to appear again on history's stage'. Could anything better enhance our anticipation of the drama's significance than this?

The narrator's introduction to the drama in 1:7–8 is modelled on ancient Greek drama. For example, in Aeschylus' *Agamemnon,* the drama opens with a speech by a 'watchman'. In the biblical tradition, the 'watchman' or 'herald' of good tidings was someone who announced 'peace'. In Isaiah 52:7–8, the watchman announces to Israel, 'Your God p 1573 reigns!' John, as a herald, is close to the OT messenger's spirit and theme. As a narrator, he alludes to large parts of the OT. So, while his drama has Greek influence and is presented in seven acts of seven scenes each, it proclaims a message in the best Hebrew and Christian prophetic tradition—that of announcing 'good tidings' in the midst of suffering.

While 1:5–6 describe what Christ accomplished on behalf of the believers, **1:7** is a clear reference to Christ's return and his eternal rule over the earth (22:7, 12, 20; Dan 7:13). Christ also introduces himself as *the Alpha and the Omega* (**1:8**), referring to the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet. The meaning is the same as that of 'the First and the Last' in 1:17, and 'the Beginning and the End' in 21:6 and 22:13. Only the book of Revelation refers to God, the Lord Jesus Christ, in this way. God wanted the readers to be encouraged by knowing that God, who knows all things from the beginning to the end, is the absolute source of all creation and history. Nothing lies outside him, just as no other letter of the Greek alphabet lay outside the Alpha and Omega. He is the Lord God of all and is continually present to his people as the Almighty (*pantokrator,* which literally means 'the one who has his hand on everything'). God is in total control (4:8; 11:17; 15:3; 16:7, 14; 19:6, 15; 2 Cor 6:18; Col 1:19).

1:9–3:22 Act I: Vision of the Church on Earth—Jesus Christ in its Midst

Stage Setting: As the curtain is drawn back on this cosmic stage, we see upon it only John (the narrator and seer) and the Son of Man, the Lord Jesus Christ. The centre of the stage is occupied by seven golden lampstands arranged in a circle.

1:9–20 The Narrator and Jesus Christ on the Stage

The stage settings for every act are adapted from OT tabernacle and temple worship. Here the seven lampstands appropriately represent the seven-branched candelabrum of the sanctuary, for the people of God are both the dwelling place of God on earth (Eph 2:19–22) and the light of the world (Matt 5:14–16).

Like the OT prophets, John directs the thoughts of readers and hearers toward the theology of history, which is the theme of his drama. Through it all, we never lose sight of the narrator who is the witness to all these events. John is always that little figure, as it were, by the side of the stage of God's activity—observing keenly and reporting faithfully what he hears (1:10) and sees (1:12).

John tells us that he was on *Patmos,* an island just off the coast of Asia Minor. He was there *because of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus* (**1:9b**). The phrase 'the testimony of Jesus'

(see also 12:17; 17:6; 19:10; 20:4) refers to the totality of the earthly life, ministry, death and resurrection of Jesus Christ. It seems that John was not on *Patmos* to preach the Word, but because either persecution or the inner compulsion of the Spirit had led him there. He assures his readers that he is their partner in three things: *suffering,* the *kingdom* and *patient endurance* (**1:9a**). John and his Christian recipients shared with Christ and with one another the suffering and persecution that comes to all believers as a result of their faithfulness to God (John 16:33; Acts 14:22; Col 1:24; 2 Tim 3:12).

The phrase *I was in the Spirit* (**1:10**) is common in apocalyptic literature, but not in any other NT book. It has been understood to indicate some kind of visionary state inspired by the Spirit (see also 4:2; 17:3). The phrase introduces the apocalyptic section of the book (4:2) immediately following the letters to the seven churches, and shows that events of the Spirit as opposed to earthly events are occurring.

John turns in order to *see* as well as to *hear* the one speaking to him (**1:12**). The *voice* could be that of Christ (as in 1:17–18; 4:1; 22:16) or, more likely, that of an angel who appears frequently in Revelation (19:10; 22:8–9). Either of these could appear to John in human form (1:13). John twice mistakenly prostrates himself before an angel, thinking that the angel is the risen Lord Jesus. John compares this voice to *a trumpet* (4:1; Exod 19:16). In chapters 8 and 9, trumpet blasts will herald woes.

The voice like a trumpet commands John to write to the seven churches what he sees and hears (**1:11**). Revelation is unique in the NT in that John functions as a scribe who writes upon command. Events in Revelation unfold in the seer's psychic vision. This does not mean that the events are illusionary or creations of his mind. Instead, this is one form of God's revelation. Often John uses the visionary qualifier *like* (1:9, 10, 13, 14, 15, 16) as he gropes to find language to convey adequately the awesome and stirring images that have confronted him. Sometimes he himself does not even understand the visions (17:6b), and yet he faithfully records everything he sees and hears. If apocalyptic writers like John, Daniel and Ezekiel could not always understand what they had been asked to record, who are we, as modern readers, to claim that we can fully understand and explain every image and symbol in Revelation?

Jesus Christ now reveals himself first to John and then to the seven churches. John's description of the risen and ascended Christ in 1:13–14 uses OT imagery to portray his wisdom, power, steadfastness and penetrating vision. He appears as *someone 'like a son of man'* standing in the middle of the golden lampstands (**1:13**; Dan 7:13). Jesus preferred the title 'Son of Man' for himself throughout his earthly ministry, though he did not deny the appropriate use of 'Son of God' as well (2:18; John 10:36; Mark 14:61). Both titles were used for the Messiah. Thus the person John is seeing is a heavenly Messiah who is also human.

p 1574 Alluding to Daniel 7:9, John describes Christ's head and hair as *white like wool, as white as snow* (**1:14a**). In ancient Middle Eastern cultures, as in most African traditional cultures, white hair commanded respect and it indicated the wisdom of years. This part of the vision may have shown John something of the deity and wisdom of Christ (Col 2:3). Christ's eyes are like a *blazing fire* (**1:14b**), a detail not found in the vision of the Son of Man in Daniel 7, but occurring in Daniel 10:6. This detail is repeated in the letter to Thyatira (2:18) and in the vision of the anticipated triumphant return of Christ and defeat of his enemies (19:12). It may also portray his penetrating scrutiny and knowledge of hidden things, or his fierce judgment (2 Chr 16:9).

The glory and majesty of Jesus Christ are apparent in the description of his feet being *like bronze glowing in a furnace* (**1:15a**; 2:18) and his voice being *like the sound of rushing waters* (**1:15b**). In Ezekiel and Daniel, God himself is described in similar terms (Ezek 1:13, 24, 27; 8:2; 43:2; Dan 10:6). The glowing bronze feet represent his triumphant trampling over those who are unbelieving and unfaithful to his truth, including the devil, the beast and the false prophet. This vision assures John of Jesus' ultimate victory over ungodly systems and political leaders who are the embodiment of evil throughout human history (Ps 2:1–12).

In Scripture, to be at someone's right hand is to be in a place of power and safety. That is why Hebrews 1:3 speaks of Jesus as seated at the right hand of God the Father in heaven after he accomplished what God the Father had sent him to do on earth. In *his right hand* Jesus is holding *seven stars* (**1:16a**), which are identified as the seven angels of the seven churches. In the Bible, *stars* can also be used to refer to angels (9:1; Job 38:7), the declaration of God's glory (Ps 19:1–4), faithful witnesses to God's truth (Dan 12:3; Matt 2:2; Luke 2:9–10) or God's messengers. The context would determine which one of these is meant.

John sees *a sharp double-edged sword* coming out of the mouth of Christ. This image is used several times in Revelation (**1:16b**; 2:12, 16; 19:15, 21). As a weapon, a sword is a symbol of war, oppression, anguish and political authority. However, John here uses a rare Greek word for sword, which outside Revelation is only used in Luke 2:35. This parallel seems to suggest that Christ conquers the world through his death and resurrection, which is a different type of 'sword'. This is the sword of divine judgment, not of the type of power wielded by the nations (Ps 2:1–12).

Finally, Christ's face is likened to *the sun shining in all its brilliance* (**1:16c**), an image that speaks of his divine glory, pre-eminence and victory (10:1; Matt 13:43; 17:2).

John's encounter with the glorified Christ is such a stupendous experience that he falls to the ground, as did Paul, Ezekiel and Daniel in similar circumstances (**1:17a**; Acts 9:3–4; 22:6–7; Ezek 1:28; 3:23; 43:3; 44:4; Dan 10:7–9). He hears Christ announce that he is *the First and the Last* (**1:17b**). This statement of eternal power and existence belongs only to God (Isa 44:6; 48:12), and so Christ is here presented as God, the Creator and the absolute Lord of history. The words are equivalent to the divine self-identification as *the Alpha and the Omega* (1:8). If the fact that he *was dead* seems to contradict this statement of eternal existence, we need to remember that the purpose of Christ's coming as man was to die the death that was due the entire sinful human race. Therefore he says not only, *I was dead,* but also exclaims, *behold, I am alive for ever and ever* (**1:18a**). Only Jesus who is truly the *Living One* can reveal himself by deeds that verify his claim to be the Lord of life.

Only the Living One could further claim, *I have the keys of death and of Hades* (**1:18b**). 'Hades' is often used to translate Hebrew references to 'the grave'. It sometimes refers to the place of all the departed dead (Acts 2:27, 31), and sometimes to the place of only the departed wicked (Luke 16:23; Rev 20:13–14). Christ's conquest of death and emergence from Hades has given him their 'keys', the symbols that he has the power and authority to enter them. He alone has authority to determine who will enter 'death and Hades' and when they will come out. For the Christian, death is the servant of Christ.

John is told to *write, therefore, what you have seen, what is now and what will take place* (**1:19**). Some commentators see this verse as presenting a chronological outline of the visions in the book, so that it refers to the past ('have seen'), the present ('now') and the future (what will take place).

The main problem with adopting such an outline is determining where exactly the breaks should take place in the book.

This first vision is called a *mystery* (**1:20**). In the NT, a mystery is something formerly secret but now revealed. The secret of the stars and lampstands is explained as showing that Jesus, the Lord of human history, is intimately involved with the people of God and is in the midst of his church.

2:1–3:22 The Letters to the Seven Churches

Jesus Christ next reveals himself to and evaluates seven specific churches. The letters were not addressed to these seven churches because they were the only Christian communities in the Roman Empire. Nor were they actually addressed exclusively to them. Rather, seven churches were chosen because seven was the number of completeness, and thus these seven churches represent the whole of the believing community of God. Most of them were experiencing persecution, and some were being tempted to compromise with the systems and powers of evil.

Similar situations face churches throughout the world today. Some are persecuted, with their members being added to the long list of Christian martyrs. Some are living in conditions of social injustice and are involved in a difficult p 1575 struggle to change those conditions. Others, like the church in Laodicea, are rich, safe and respected, and yet they are spiritually bankrupt. We need to use our ears to 'hear what the Spirit says to the churches'—to all of them, rich and poor, weak and powerful, secure and persecuted; to churches in America, Angola, Bolivia, Britain, Canada, Chad, China, Congo, Namibia, Uganda, Yemen, Zanzibar, and in our own backyard. We should care about what is happening with the Christian church worldwide.

The seven churches were, however, more than just symbols, they were also real churches in real places, situated along a natural ancient travel circuit, beginning at Ephesus and ending at Laodicea. And each of the letters is adapted to the specific situation of the church it addresses.

These letters are all constructed on the same pattern. Each contains some commendation (except the letter to Laodicea), a reproof, an exhortation to correct what is wrong, and a promise to *him who overcomes* (2:7, 11, 17, 26; 3:5, 12, 21). Affirmation is something we find difficult in ministry. It seems much easier to find fault than to compliment. But these letters offer a pattern of affirmation and correction, challenge and comfort. Such a balance is not only biblical but very necessary in pastoral ministry. Weakness and fallibility can be opportunities for spiritual growth and strength (2 Cor 12:9).

The goal of each letter is to encourage the recipients to endure to the end, remaining loyal and faithful to Christ. These letters also suggest that there are limits as to how much Christians should compromise with contemporary culture or political policies. We need to recognize conflicts of interest and to be aware of the extent to which our belief and behaviour are influenced by our own culture. Our reputation in society and culture counts for little if our lifestyle is against God.

We might be inclined to think of these letters as private communications from John to each of the churches, but there is nothing to indicate that they were circulated separately. The book of Revelation was intended to be read as a whole in public in all the churches in the region (1:3). Thus, believers in Ephesus would hear not only the message addressed directly to them but also the messages to Smyrna, Sardis and the rest. This approach makes it clear that there was a common bond uniting all these communities into one. It also means that the message of the whole would

have come into sharper focus for each local church because each one would have heard its needs addressed in concrete terms within the context of the wider church.

The unity of all these churches is symbolized by at least three features that appear in all the letters:

- Each letter is addressed to *the angel of the church.* The word 'angel' in Greek means 'a messenger'. This description challenges church leaders to take their work more seriously. In some ways, the pastor of a church embodies the qualities (or lack of them) that characterize that local church. A pastor, in a sense, distils the character of the belief and behaviour of the individual Christians.
- All the letters begin with a statement about the one whose message is being communicated. Jesus introduces himself to the churches using the same descriptions of himself he used in revealing himself to John in 1:12–20.
- Finally, all the letters end with the same exhortation: *he who has an ear let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches* (2:7, 11, 17, 29; 3:6, 13, 22). This was not just an empty formula. It placed the responsibility on the shoulders of the recipients. The only excuse anyone could have for not responding to what the Spirit had to say was that he or she had no ears! Anyone who had ears had no excuse. This formula is used to link together the messages to all the churches. We might expect the letters to call for each church to hear its own message. But the plural term was used, *churches.* Each local church was to hear and heed the word that was spoken to all the other churches as well as to itself.

2:1–7 Act I, Scene 1: The church at Ephesus

The church at Ephesus could be any local congregation in the history of Christianity. The Lord Jesus' message to it reveals his intimate knowledge of the spiritual condition of all his people. He knows each one of us as we really are inside (1 Sam 16:7; Ps 139:1–24; 2 Tim 2:19; Heb 4:12). Nothing is hidden from his eyes (2 Chr 16:9).

Ephesus was one of the richest cities of the ancient world. Located on a harbour at the tip of Asia Minor, it was a centre of trade and travel. Its people were proud of their city, and especially of the temple of Artemis (also known as Diana), who was worshipped as the source of fertility and abundance. Thus her statue had many breasts. Her temple was one of the great tourist attractions of the ancient Mediterranean world. The city's pride in its trade and religion is clear from the incident in Acts 19:23–41 and the chant 'Great is Artemis of the Ephesians' (Acts 19:34).

p 1576 Paul has written a letter to the church in Ephesus, but now Jesus Christ reveals himself to them as *him who holds the seven stars in his right hand and walks among the seven golden lampstands* (**2:1**; 1:13) and brings a message of both praise and warning. The church is praised because, in the midst of such overt idolatry and some persecution, it has *persevered and endured hardships for my name's sake* and *not grown weary* (**2:3**). As a congregation, the believers have rejected some who had falsely claimed to be apostles (**2:2**) and they hate *the works of the Nicolaitans* (2:6—see comment on 2:14–15). On the other hand, they are rebuked for having abandoned the love which originally characterized their lives and warned that if they do not repent, the Lord will take their lampstand from its place (**2:4–5**). That is, they will no longer be counted among the faithful witnesses of Christ in their own generation.

As far as Christian service was concerned, the members were hard-working. But they lacked devotion to Christ. Believers in every generation are in danger of becoming experts at ministry, simply performing tasks rather than deepening their passion for Christ. If they do, they will become like salt that has lost its saltiness (Matt 5:13). We need to maintain a proper balance.

2:8–11 Act I, Scene 2: The church at Smyrna

Smyrna (now Izmir), situated some thirty-five miles (fifty kilometres) north of Ephesus, was another flourishing city in the Roman province of Asia Minor. How appropriate is the Lord's self-designation as *the First and the Last, who died and came to life again* (**2:8**; 1:8, 17), for a church whose members, as this letter shows, were facing persecution and the threat of death.

Like Ephesus, Smyrna was noted for its pagan worship. Here, however, the worship took forms that were potentially more dangerous for this community of believers. Thus John can only write words of comfort to the church in Smyrna. By being faithful unto death, the church will not be *hurt by the second death* (**2:11**). The *crown of life* that is promised is similar to the laurel wreath worn by an athlete who wins a race, but the emphasis is on finishing the Christian race or pilgrimage well and not on competitive zeal. Persecution has taught the Christians in Smyrna that 'a man's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions' but in being 'rich towards God' (Luke 12:15, 21). The church in the developing world may not have material wealth, but may it long continue increasing in richness toward God in the midst of persecution and material scarcity.

The reference to *the slander of those who say they are Jews and are not, but are a synagogue of Satan* (**2:9**) may indicate early hostility to true Christians (see comment on 3:9). But the one behind the persecution is really *Satan* or 'the devil' (the terms are used interchangeably—12:9; 20:2). He may use religious individuals or groups as his instruments in persecuting the faithful. God never promises believers a suffering-free life on this side of eternity. But he promises them his presence in every situation (Ps 23:4; Matt 28:19–20; Heb 13:5).

2:12–17 Act I, Scene 3: The church at Pergamum

The city of Pergamum was located about sixty miles (one-hundred kilometres) north of Smyrna and fifteen miles (twenty-five kilometres) from the coast. It was the headquarters of both the Roman authority and emperor worship in the province of Asia Minor. That is probably why it is called the place *where Satan has his throne* (**2:13a**). However, some interpret this phrase as referring to the temple of Zeus, which was situated on a hill above the city and might be compared to a throne. But it seems more likely that John was thinking of Roman power as the embodiment of evil during his time, and thus as a symbol of the satanic powers that were upon the earth.

Pergamum was also famous for its magnificent library, which rivalled that of Alexandria. Disputes about which was the best library in the world had resulted in Egypt's stopping all shipments of papyrus to Pergamum. Then the city began copying its books onto animal skins. This material was given the name of *parchment*—that is, 'writing material from Pergamum'. Most of the ancient manuscripts of the NT were written on parchment.

The message to the church in Pergamum is sent from the one *who has the sharp double-edged sword* (**2:12**; 1:16). This is a reference to the coming victory and judgment of Christ. Jesus commends

the church for its steadfastness in the very centre of Satan's domain, as exemplified by Antipas, who died for his faith (**2:13b**). God never forgets his martyrs.

However, Jesus also reproves the church for the false doctrines that have spread among them, specifically the teachings of *Balaam* and of *the Nicolaitans* (**2:14–15**). Balaam is an OT prototype of all the false teachers who misled Israel (Num 23–24; 31:16). According to some Jewish writers of the time, both Balaam and Nicolaus mean 'destroyer of the people'. John is saying that, as in times of old, there are those whose teachings destroy people doctrinally and spiritually by inciting them to compromise with idolatry. In this context *sexual immorality* probably has the symbolic meaning, common in the OT, of spiritual adultery, leaving the true God and following idols. The call to repentance is coupled with a warning of judgment on the basis of the Word of God. The community of God's people is no place for compromise.

Christ promises those at Pergamum *who overcome* that he will give them *the hidden manna* and *a white stone with a new name written on it* (**2:17**). 'The hidden manna' probably refers to the manna hidden in the ark of the covenant by Moses (Exod 16:33–34; Heb 9:4), which reminded the children of Israel of God's grace, faithfulness and provision in the wilderness (Ps 78:24). According to apocalyptic Jewish teaching, the messianic era would see the restoration of the hidden wilderness manna: 'And it shall come to pass at that self-same time [in the days when the Messiah comes] that the treasury of manna shall again descend from on high, and they will eat of it in those years' (*2 Baruch* 29:8). The 'manna' may also refer to Holy Communion, which looks to the past, present and future when believers, as citizens of the kingdom, will eat manna at the heavenly banquet. It may also speak of the ever-sufficiency of Jesus Christ in contrast to the allurements of emperor worship.

The 'white stone' probably refers to an invitation or 'admission ticket' that entitled its bearer to attend a banquet. In the ancient world, a *white stone* was a ballot of approval and a token of admission, whereas a black stone denoted rejection and exclusion. Accordingly, the *white stone* p 1577 promised to the person who overcomes signifies acceptance by the Lord and a place among the company of his redeemed.

Some interpret the 'new name' on the stone as a secret divine name. They cite verses such as 3:12, where the Lord says he will write the name of his God and his own new name on the one who overcomes; and 14:1, where the 144,000 have the name of the Lamb and the name of his Father written on their foreheads; and 22:4, where it is said that the name of the Lord will be on the foreheads of his servants in the new heaven and earth. Those who are thus stamped with the divine name are marked as precious to God and his special possession. But here in 2:17, it is not the person but the white stone that is marked with a name that is *known only to him who receives it.* It thus seems that this verse is not speaking of a divine name, but, rather, of a divinely given name for each person who overcomes. 'Overcoming' involves perseverance in living for God in all life situations. When we fail, we must immediately acknowledge our failure or sin and confess it before the Lord (1 John 1:9). The name known only to the recipient indicates the uniqueness of each individual believer before the Lord, and the distinctness of the relationship each person has with God. There will be no confusion of names in the mind of God. What is revealed to John here is really the fulfilment of the age-old promise 'You shall be called by a new name which the mouth of the Lord will give' (Isa 62:2). The Good Shepherd 'calls his own sheep by name … and the sheep follow him for they know his voice' (John 10:3–4).

2:18–29 Act I, Scene 4: The church at Thyatira

Unlike the previous three cities, Thyatira had no political significance, though it had a few things it could be proud of. It stood at an important crossroads about thirty-five miles (fifty-six kilometres) south-east of Pergamum and was a commercial town with many traders and artisans. Ancient records indicate that it had more craftsmen's guilds than many larger cities. It was the home of Lydia, 'a dealer in purple cloth' (Acts 16:14), who became a disciple of Paul. She must have been a member of the dyers' guild. These guilds wielded significant power. They combined some of the features of our modern trade unions with some religious features. Each guild had its own patron deity, feasts and seasonal festivals. Individuals had to belong to a guild in order to practise a certain trade, and had to participate in their meetings and ceremonies. These guild meetings often took place in pagan temples, where an animal was offered to the gods and then eaten by the members of the guild. This obviously presented Christians with a dilemma. If they did not participate in such feasts and ceremonies, they would be unable to make a living from trading. If they did participate, they were being unfaithful to their Lord. Many African Christians find themselves in similar situations. Senior members of African families usually expect all family members to cooperate and participate in all pagan rituals and festivals which are aimed at appeasing the spirits of the departed relatives.

This church shows *love, faith, service* and *perseverance* (**2:19**) and was apparently a growing church. However, it has permitted the false teaching of a self-proclaimed prophetess, who may have proposed an easy way out of this dilemma. In the previous letter, people with similar views were likened to Balaam, and here this woman is described as a new *Jezebel* (**2:20**; see 1 Kgs 16:31; 18:4; 19:2; 21:1–25). She leads the people into spiritual adultery and *Satan's so-called deep secrets* (**2:24**). If the congregation does not repent, the Lord will abandon them to sensual ways, so that their judgment will be in accord with their deeds (**2:21–22**). Beware of so-called prophets or apostles who teach 'secret doctrines'!

In contrast, those who hear and obey the words of the one *whose eyes are like a blazing of fire* (**2:18**; 1:14) will receive *authority over the nations* (**2:26**). What is promised here is union with Christ in his universal authority, as is clear from the explanation *just as I have received authority from my Father.* The basis of the promise is the declaration prophetically addressed to the incarnate Son: 'Ask of me, and I will make the nations your inheritance and the ends of the earth your possession. You shall rule them with an iron sceptre; you will dash them to pieces like pottery' (Ps 2:8, 9). The profound blessing of reigning with Christ is exclusively for believers (1 Cor 6:2–3). He can give them this privilege because he is the *Son of God* (2:18), a term that appears only here in the entire book, for elsewhere 'Son of Man' is preferred (1:13; 14:14). He may have chosen to use this title here to contrast the glory of the Christ with the pretensions of the emperor cult that hailed Caesar as a god.

The overcomers in Thyatira are promised *the morning star* (**2:28**). This expression may refer to the Son of God in his glory (22:16), or to the resurrection of believers, or both ideas may be combined. In the present night of this fallen world, the light of the eternal day has already dawned in the hearts of those who by faith have received him who is the morning star into their lives. The promise of his return is also like the *morning star* (2 Pet 1:19), which heralds the start of a new day as the darkness of the long night of temptation, persecution, suffering and death is dispelled. Overcomers are promised resurrection and participation in Christ's glory in that kingdom where there will be no night (21:25). Those whose hearts are illumined by divine grace (2 Cor 4:4, 6) will find that 'the path of the righteous is like the first gleam of dawn, shining ever brighter till the full light of day' (Prov 4:18).

This message to the church at Thyatira reminds us that we need to seriously evaluate ourselves as local churches p 1578 and as individual believers, to see what the Lord is calling us to turn away from. Are our beliefs, behaviour, doctrine, deeds, motives and actions in keeping with what God expects of us as individuals and congregations (1 Cor 11:28)?

3:1–6 Act I, Scene 5: The church at Sardis

Sardis was about thirty miles (fifty kilometres) south of Thyatira and was a prosperous city. Five important roads met there, which made for active trade and gave the city strategic importance. The surrounding area was particularly well-suited to raising sheep, and so Sardis was a centre for the trade in wool and cloth.

The majority of those in the church were spiritually weak. But a few are commended for their faithfulness to the Lord (**3:4**). The Lord knows even those few who are faithful to him (2 Tim 2:19). However, there is very little that is positive in the message to Sardis. It can be summarized in its opening statement: *You have a reputation of being alive, but you are dead* (**3:1;** 2 Tim 3:5). Strikingly, there is no mention of any particular sins as in the other letters, nor is there any reference to persecution, external pressures, or false doctrines within the church. On the contrary, everything seems to be running smoothly. That apparent smoothness seems to have been the great tragedy of the church in Sardis. Its easy life is its greatest indictment. The Lord sees that the church at Sardis is spiritually asleep. Therefore, he exhorts the church to *Wake up!* (**3:3**). The church has to strengthen what remained, or else it will die (**3:2**).

The promise made to overcomers grows out of the reference to white clothing in **3:5**. The faithful Sardian Christians will receive white clothes from Christ, and so will any others who overcome the pollution of pagan society. Furthermore, this pure relationship to Christ is permanently guaranteed: *I will never blot out his name from the book of life.* In ancient times, the names of citizens were recorded in a register. When they died, their names were erased or crossed out of the book of the living. This same idea appears in the OT (Exod 32:32–33; Ps 69:28; Isa 4:3). From this idea of being recorded in God's book of the living (or the righteous) comes the sense of belonging to God's eternal kingdom or possessing eternal life (Dan 12:1; Luke 10:20; Phil 4:3; Heb 12:23; Rev 13:8; 17:8; 20:15; 21:27). For Christ to say that he will never blot out or erase the overcomers' names from the book of life is the strongest possible affirmation that death can never separate believers from Christ (Rom 8:35–39). A person enrolled in the book of life by faith remains in it forever.

Finally, Christ promises *to acknowledge* the names of overcomers *before the Father and his angels.* The word translated 'acknowledge' implies a strong confession before a court. Christ's confession of our names is a statement of our fellowship and oneness with him that assures our heavenly citizenship (Matt 10:32; Luke 12:8). What ultimately counts is not our acceptance by this world's society but that our eternal relationship to Christ is genuine.

3:7–13 Act I, Scene 6: The church at Philadelphia

Philadelphia was about twenty-five miles (forty kilometres) south-east of Sardis on a main highway that connected it to other cities like Smyrna and Pergamum. It was less important than most of the other six cities. Its source of wealth was the flourishing vineyards on the surrounding volcanic plains. Consequently, its main religious allegiance was to Dionysius, the god of wine. Philadelphia was also

famous for its many other shrines, though none was as great or as beautiful as the temple of Artemis in Ephesus. According to some authors, there was a custom of inscribing the name of great citizens on the pillars of these temples. This custom may be the background for the promise: *Him who overcomes, I will make a pillar in the temple of my God* (3:12).

The letter is free from rebuke, even though the church in Philadelphia would seem not to have been a strong church. The description of the one who speaks as *holy* and *true* (**3:7a**; 6:10) reminds the members of the church that they are called to be holy and obedient to revealed biblical truth (1 Pet 1:15–16).

The further statement that the speaker *has the key of David,* and that *what he opens, no one can shut, and what he shuts, no one can open* (**3:7b**) reminds us of Isaiah 22:22, where very similar words are used of Eliakim, whom God would put in charge of Hezekiah's household (2 Kgs 18:18, 37). Christ, who has been appointed 'head over everything for the church' (Eph 1:22) and invested with 'all authority' (Matt 28:18), is 'faithful … over God's house' (Heb 3:6). *The key* that he holds is a symbol of the trust placed in him and of his authority. It is called *the key of David* because Christ is the promised descendent of David whose kingdom will be established for ever (2 Sam 7:13, 16; Isa 9:7; Luke 1:32; Rev 22:16). The supremacy of his authority is indicated by the assertion that what he opens 'no one can shut' and what he shuts 'no one can open'. Even death, which to us seems so final, is not the end. He wields the key of death and of Hades (1:18) and thus has ultimate power both as redeemer and as judge (John 5:22–29).

As with all the churches, the Lord knows the strengths and weaknesses of the Philadelphian church (**3:8a**; 2 Chr 16:9). Continuing the idea of opening and shutting, he declares that he has opened a door for them, and because he is the one who has opened it, no one else will be able to shut it (**3:8b**). In the past, God had made a similar announcement to Cyrus (Isa 45:1). The door that has opened for the church is not the door through which they can escape their difficult circumstances. Rather, it is a door of opportunity to witness to the power of the gospel (2 Cor 1:4). Paul used a similar metaphor when he explained how God had 'opened p 1579 the door of faith to the Gentiles' (Acts 14:27; see also 1 Cor 16:9; Col 4:3). The believers in Philadelphia faced fearsome opposition, but this hostility could not shut the door that God had opened.

Those opposing their witness are described as *of the synagogue of Satan* (**3:9**; see 2:9). It seems that there were some Jews who vehemently denied that Jesus was Lord and Messiah and who actively persecuted those who made that claim. They are said to *claim to be Jews though they are not, but are liars.* A true Jew, according to Paul and John, is one who finds forgiveness and life in Jesus, the Messiah.

The word *since* that introduces 3:10 may belong with 3:9, and may thus be saying that the reason for the believers' triumph over the synagogue of Satan is that Christ loves them because they follow his *command to endure patiently* (**3:10a**). This command may be the one to endure until he returns (Luke 21:19; Heb 10:36–38) or it may be the command to endure as patiently as Christ himself did (2 Thess 3:5; Heb 12:1–5).

But the 'since' may also point forward, as in the NIV translation, to a promise of deliverance because of their obedience. This promise has also sparked debate about what exactly is meant by the phrase *keep you from the hour of trial* (**3:10b**). The Greek may equally well be translated as 'keep you from undergoing the trial' or 'keep you right through the trial'. In other NT passages, the same

expression means to be kept from the pollution of the world while still in the world (John 17:15–19; Jas 1:27).

There is also debate about what constitutes 'the hour of trial'. It is clearly a very thoroughgoing test *that is going to come upon the whole world* and apply to all *those who live on the earth.* Some interpret it as the time of intense trouble that will come on the world before the second coming of Christ (Dan 12:1; Joel 2:31; Mark 13:14; 2 Thess 2:1–12). They argue that this trial is the one described in detail in the following chapters of the book of Revelation, and that the Lord is here promising to exempt believers from the fierce persecution yet to come.

Others argue that 'the hour of trial' is the wrath of God from which believers are eternally delivered. Certainly, the book of Revelation as a whole does not promise believers escape from suffering but encourages them to endure it to the end. They have already known suffering, as when Antipas, the faithful witness of Christ, was martyred (2:13). p 1580 Martyrdom is, in fact, presented as the means of conquering for both Christ and his followers (5:6). While Christians are not called to seek martyrdom, they are to remain faithful until Christ either calls them home or comes back for them before death. Physical death is not the end of everything for the believer (Matt 10:28; John 14:1–3; 1 Cor 15:51–53; 2 Cor 5:6, 8; 1 Thess 4:13–18). In all their hardships and suffering, they will experience God's shepherding ministry (Ps 23:4; Heb 13:5).

In light of the Lord's anticipated return, the believers should persevere so that they will not lose their promised rewards (**3:11**; 1 Cor 9:24–27). The first reward is becoming a *pillar in the temple of my God* (**3:12a**). Philadelphia suffered frequent earthquakes, and often the only parts of the city left standing were the huge stone columns of temples. These pillars were thus symbols of strength, stability and permanence. Moreover, they were a vital part of the whole building. So the Lord is promising that overcomers will have a place of abiding power and dignity in the coming kingdom of God in which no persecution or trials will ever disturb them again.

Secondly, Christ promises the overcomer, *I will write on him the name of my God and the name of the city of my God, the new Jerusalem, … and … my new name* (**3:12b**). The name of the city of Philadelphia had been changed by several rulers in the past, but believers are reminded that the name will come from God himself (not the emperor) and will ensure their citizenship in the new Jerusalem (21:2; Ezek 48:35). Christ's *new name* could be either the name that he alone knows about, signifying his absolute power over all creation (19:12), or the *new name* of Christ given to the believer (Isa 62:2; 65:15). This name is the seal of overcomers' salvation in Christ, who has redeemed them at the infinite cost of his own precious blood, and to whom they therefore belong (1 Cor 6:19; 1 Pet 1:18–19; Rev 7:14–15).

THEOLOGICAL HERESY

The word 'theology' literally means 'God's word'. Christian theology thus involves reflection on our faith and worship in the light of God's word and our contemporary context. Every theology worthy of the name must be deeply rooted in the Scriptures and must not deliberately distort God's word or promote a false interpretation of it that leads to error being accepted as truth.

'Heresy' refers to deviation from the doctrinal beliefs commonly accepted by the Christian church. Most of the theological heresies in church history have had to do with the nature of Jesus Christ, the Trinity, the second coming of Christ and the ethical implications of the Christian message for moral life today. Today, in our African context, common heresies include the teaching that all humans will be saved, the elevation of African traditional religion as equivalent to OT faith, ancestor worship, and the mixing of African traditional religion and Christianity.

Theological heresy was seen by the apostles and the early church fathers as a serious and rebellious departure from established doctrine. In the Pastoral Epistles, the elders are instructed to teach sound doctrine and oppose false teaching (1 Tim 1:3–11; 4:1–16; 2 Tim 1:13–14; 4:1–5; Titus 1:9–2:1). 'False teachers' and 'destructive heresies' are also strongly opposed in 2 Peter 2. Such teachers are described as despising legitimate authority (2 Pet 2:10b–13a) and following the corrupt desires of their sinful nature (2 Pet 2:13b–16). They are said to be dry springs, powerless in dealing with sin (2 Pet 2:19) and destined for judgment (2 Pet 2:20–22).

Three heretical groups are identified in the NT, namely, Judaizers, Gnostics and Nicolaitans. The Judaizers taught that salvation required both faith in Jesus and obedience to the law of Moses. The Gnostics claimed to possess special insight and taught that Jesus was not really God's Son and that matter was evil and spirit good. Since God was good (and Spirit) he could not personally have created a material world (evil). Also, since spirit and matter could not intermingle, Christ and God could not have united in the person of Jesus (2 Tim 2:17–18). The Nicolaitans practised an extreme form of Gnosticism, claiming that since their bodies were physical (and therefore evil), only what their spirits did was important. They felt free to indulge in promiscuous sexual relationships, to eat food that had been offered to idols and to do anything they pleased with their bodies (1 and 2 John; Rev 2:6, 14, 15).

The early church responded strongly to those who deviated from the truth and claimed to have special knowledge outside the biblical text, as can be seen in the epistles and in the action taken in Acts 15:1–31. It barred heretics from its fellowship and prayed for their salvation. It did not, however, call for them to be put to death, and the church was wrong when it later began executing those it considered heretical.

Believers must take care not to label legitimate differences in emphasis within the Christian church as heretical. The differences in theological emphases between, say, Presbyterian and Pentecostal churches do not constitute heresy because both groups can adequately justify their different approaches from Scripture.

James Nkansah-Obrempong

Adeyemo, T. (2006). *Africa Bible commentary*. Nairobi, Kenya; Grand Rapids, MI: WordAlive Publishers; Zondervan.

3:14–22 Act I, Scene 7: The church at Laodicea

Laodicea was about forty-five miles (seventy kilometres) south-east of Philadelphia. Like many of the cities mentioned in these two chapters, Laodicea was rich. It was proud of its power and prosperity, and had a famous school of medicine. There were several sources of that prosperity, but two among them seem to be significant in relation to this letter. One was beautiful bluish-black wool, which contrasts with the *white clothes* of sanctification (**3:18b**). The other was a world-famous eye ointment. John refers to this ointment when he counsels the church to buy from Christ *salve to put on your eyes so that you can see* (**3:18c**).

The apathy of this church disgusts the Lord. It's spiritual poverty is extreme. What is that great sin of the Laodiceans that causes Christ, *the faithful and true witness* (3:14) to say that he will spit them out (**3:16**)? From the text, their sin is not something they do or think. It is rather that they are comfortable, smug, and lukewarm (**3:15**). Thus the Lord says to them: *You say, 'I am rich, I have acquired wealth and do not need a thing.' But you do not realize that you are wretched, pitiable, poor, blind and naked* (**3:17**). Christ encourages the church to seek true riches in him, as well as purity and spiritual sight. There is still hope for Laodicea, for Christ is standing at the door and knocking (**3:20–21**). Some churches today are like the church in Laodicea; rich, safe and respected, and yet they are spiritually bankrupt. If they open their heart to God for meaningful fellowship and spiritual revival, they will enjoy Christ's intimate daily fellowship.

4:1–8:1 Act II: Vision of God in Heaven—The Opening of the Seven Seals

Stage Setting: A great change of scenery is required for act II—*a door standing open in heaven* (4:1). In the middle of the stage appears the throne of God (4:2). Other characters on the stage include the twenty-four elders (4:4), four creatures (4:6) and, on the other side, the narrator (4:1). Before the throne are the Lamb (5:6), the seven lamps (4:5) and a sea of glass (4:6). As in most of the acts of this drama, the description of the activity in heaven forms part of the background for the scenes that will follow. John is saying that the events of history and of man's salvation must be viewed in light of God's redemptive purpose.

4:1–5:14 God in Control

The visionary scenes begin in chapter 4 with an incomparable picture of God's throne in heaven (4:2–8). He is presented as *the Lord God Almighty* (4:8), the one who created the world, and who is totally in control of things. Evil has been allowed, not because God is powerless against it, but because for his own purposes he has given it room to operate within the world for a limited and specified time.

Why has God allowed what appears to be contrary to divine purpose to have free rein in the world? The book of Revelation does not give a direct answer to this question. There are, however, two considerations from the point of view of the whole biblical message. The first is what is often referred to as the divine patience: 'The Lord is merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love' (Ps 103:8). 'Do you show contempt for the riches of his kindness, tolerance and patience, not realising that God's kindness leads you towards repentance?' (Rom 2:4). When we recognize ourselves to be sinful, then God's patience is a characteristic we celebrate! However, in a

time of great tribulation and persecution God's patience with evil can seem strange. Suffering Christians must then be patient and remain faithful to God until his purpose, already begun in the heavenly realms, is carried out on earth (Jas 1:2–4). The second consideration is that God has created a humanity p 1581 that could choose to be obedient, and thus could also choose to be disobedient. God did not design human puppets or robots. Thus the message of the Bible stresses the need for each of us to choose to know and obey God's will.

4:1–3 God on his throne

John is summoned by the voice, *like a trumpet,* which he had heard at the beginning (1:10). God and his throne are described in images drawn from Ezekiel's vision of the throne-chariot (**4:2**; see Ezek 1–2; Dan 7:9–10). This scene in heaven is very impressive, but may seem obscure and incoherent when examined in detail. John speaks of things that lie utterly beyond human knowledge. He describes the one sitting on the throne as having *the appearance of jasper and carnelian* (**4:3**). These are precious stones, although we are not certain exactly which stones are referred to. *Jasper* may be the same reddish stone as modern jasper, but John may have been referring to green jade or quartz, or even to diamond because elsewhere it is said to be 'clear as crystal' (21:11). *Carnelian* (or 'sardius'—KJV) was a red stone, and could also have been a ruby. Jasper, carnelian and *emerald* were all precious and costly. The flashes of light from such precious stones are an appropriate symbol of the divine presence, at once restrained as regards detail, but clear as regards majesty. It is interesting to note that sardius and jasper are the first and last of the twelve precious stones in the high priest's breastplate, each of which was inscribed with the name of one of the tribes of Israel (Exod 28:17–21).

Like all apocalypses, the vision overwhelms the reader with a sense of the majesty and awe of God, and serves as a forceful reminder that God, and not any earthly ruler or power, is sovereign over the whole universe and that he alone is worthy of worship.

The throne of God is the focal point of the stage. In both the tent of meeting and the temple in the OT, God's throne was the lid of the ark of the covenant between the worshipping cherubim. The ark stood in the inner part of the sanctuary (the holy of holies). What John sees here is thus the open sanctuary.

4:4–11 God's creatures worship him

In apocalyptic literature, numbers are usually symbolic. Thus the *twenty-four elders* (**4:4**) probably represent the people of God, symbolized by the twelve tribes of Israel and the twelve apostles. They would also remind Jewish readers of the twenty-four orders of Levites appointed to prophesy and praise in the temple (1 Chr 25).

The semicircular arrangement of the *thrones* for the elders around the central throne is similar to that of the Jewish Sanhedrin and the physical phenomena proceeding from the throne express God's power and majesty (Exod 19:16–19). The *seven lamps* (**4:5**) represent the Spirit of God, as did the seven-branched lampstand in the tabernacle (Exod 25:31–40; Zech 4:2). The *sea of glass* is like the bronze basin in the tabernacle (**4:6a**; Exod 30:17–21)—a symbol of that purity without which man cannot approach God.

The *four living creatures* represent all creation and their *eyes* God's intimate knowledge of all his works (**4:6b**; Ezek 1:5–21). The creatures, one like a lion, one like an ox, one like an eagle and the last with the face of a man, lead the heavenly entourage in continual worship of God. A rabbinic saying says: 'The mightiest among the birds is the eagle, the mightiest among the domestic animals is the bull, the mightiest among the beasts is the lion, and the mightiest among all is man.' The four forms suggest whatever is noblest, strongest, wisest, and swiftest in the natural world, including humankind, is represented before the throne, taking its part in fulfilling the divine will, and worshipping the divine majesty.

We are familiar with the words of worship in the hymn setting: Holy, Holy, Holy, Lord God Almighty (**4:8**; see also Isa 6:3). The twenty-four elders lay their crowns before the throne (**4:10**) and praise the Lord God as creator because he alone is the source of life (**4:11**; 1:8; Pss 33:6–9; 102:25; 136:5–9). Liturgical elements such as these rituals and hymns occur frequently in the book of Revelation. What strikes us is the all-encompassing participation of the worshippers. Worship is more than words. It can be expressed in a variety of ways as long as the focal point is worshipping God and acknowledging his absolute Lordship.

5:1–14 The scroll and Lamb in heaven

Chapter 5 is a pivotal chapter that introduces us to scenes and characters in heaven. Contrary to what we might expect after the majestic introduction, a weak creature with no mark of a victorious triumph, but only the marks of its own slaughter, is the agent of God's purpose.

The chapter starts with John seeing a scroll in the hand of God. The scroll is sealed to guarantee its authenticity and to keep its contents secret. It contains the destiny of the world, the purposes of God for all creation (see Ezek 2:9–10; Dan 10:21). As in many apocalyptic writings, the course of history is already determined. However, the heavenly council is at an impasse because no one in the universe has been found who is able to break the seven seals and open the scroll. The dramatic tension of the scene is heightened by John's beginning to weep (**5:4**). Then, one of the elders informs him that there is indeed one who can open the scroll—the Messiah, described as *the Lion of the tribe of Judah* (**5:5a**; Gen 49:9–10) and *the Root of David* (**5:5b**; 22:16; Isa 11:1, 10; Jer 23:5; 33:15). In Jewish apocalyptic literature, the lion was often used as a symbol of the conquering Messiah.

John looks for the mighty Lion, but all he sees is a *Lamb looking as if it had been slain* (**5:6**), standing in the centre of p 1582 the throne court. This vision links the sacrificial death of Christ to the OT Passover lamb (Exod 12:5–6; Isa 53:7; John 1:29, 36; Acts 8:32; 1 Pet 1:19). The slain Lamb is the crucified Christ. But this Lamb is more than a victim; he is also powerful and conquering. The Lamb has *seven horns.* In the OT, a horn is a symbol of strength (Deut 33:17) and seven is the number of perfection. Thus the *seven horns* indicate the perfect or absolute power of the Lamb. He is completely adequate for any situation. He also has *seven eyes,* which are explained as *the seven spirits of God sent out into all the earth.* This is probably not a reference to the Holy Spirit, but rather to the omniscience of the Lamb. The *seven eyes* denote perfection of seeing: nothing escapes his eyes (2 Chr 16:9; Zech 4:10).

John uses all these symbols to tell his readers that Christ, of the tribe of Judah and the line of David, is supremely powerful and all-knowing, and that he has won his victory by his atoning and sacrificial death on the cross. There is a striking combination of the utmost power and the utmost

self-giving. As Revelation emphasizes, martyrdom is the means of conquering for both Christ and his followers.

The Lamb's act calls forth a hymn of praise from the living creatures and elders (5:8–12). During the hymn, the elders act as priests by offering up *bowls full of incense,* representing the *prayers of the saints* (**5:8**; Ps 141:2). These prayers are petitions similar to those of the martyrs who call on God to judge those who killed them (6:10) and of the redeemed, whose prayers are immediately followed by the trumpets of God's judgment (8:3–5).

Previously the living creatures and the elders sang a hymn to God (4:11), but now they sing a *new song* (**5:9**), unlike anything sung before in heaven. Jesus Christ has introduced the new era of the kingdom of God (Isa 42:9–10) and the hosts of heaven sing his praise. His sacrifice on the cross shows that he is worthy of such honour (4:10–11). Through his death, he *purchased men for God.* The image here is of freeing slaves, as when God liberated Israel from Egypt to become the free people of God in the land of promise. It also points to the greater emancipation for life eternal in the kingdom of God that has been accomplished for all humanity at the cost of the Lamb's blood. The redeemed have become *a kingdom and priests to serve our God* (**5:10**), so fulfilling the vocation to which the ancient people of God were called (Exod 19:6).

Believers, as Jesus' disciples, are called to imitate our master. We need to learn humility from how Christ is introduced to the human race as the slain Lamb, and must learn to die to ourselves and take up our cross and follow him in all aspects of our life (Luke 9:23). This includes such small details as how we wish to be introduced as conference speakers or how we expect members of our congregations to address us. Titles can mean too much to us.

Next, John sees *thousands upon thousands and ten thousands times ten thousands* of angels surrounding the throne (**5:11**). This vision is similar to Daniel's vision of the countless multitudes before 'the Ancient of Days' (Dan 7:9–10). The imagery suggests the infinite honour and power of the one who is at the centre of it all and whose praises are sung in **5:12**—the Lamb.

Whereas the first hymn in this scene is sung only to God (4:10–11), and the next two are songs of praise to the Lamb (5:9–10, 12), the last hymn in **5:13–14** is a grand finale in which all of God's creatures in heaven and earth and in the sea unite in praise to both God the Father and God the Son (5:13; 7:12; Phil 2:6–11). The number of singers has increased from twenty-eight in 5:8 to *every creature in all creation* (5:13). The imagination is staggered by the numbers!

6:1–8:1 Seven Seals in Seven Scenes

When the Lamb has taken the scroll from the hand of God (**6:1**), he begins to undo the seals, and as he breaks them one by one, angels come forth and execute the appointed judgments. The opening of the seven seals (6:1–8:1) is followed by a series of woes marked by the blowing of seven trumpets (8:2–11:18). The woe of the seventh trumpet is followed by the seven bowls of the wrath of God (15:5–16:21).

In the 'seals' section, John speaks of the following disasters in vivid and imaginative language: war, civil dissent, famine, plague, persecution and earthquakes. The 'trumpets' and 'bowls' sections contain little more than a repetition of these calamities. Because John writes in such different ways about all these woes, we can easily overlook how closely the sections resemble each other. We get

the impression that the action is moving forward, while for the most part it only repeats itself. One might rightly ask why.

The answer is related to the answer to the question of the place of the seals in the context of Revelation, the church, the history of humankind and the anticipated second coming of Christ. The Lamb is said to open the seals in 6:1, 3, 5, 7, 9, and 12 and 8:1. But has the Lamb already opened the seals? Or is he sequentially opening them? Or will he open them in the future? Different answers to these difficult questions have resulted in many different interpretations of Revelation.

- Some believe that the events accompanying the opening of the seals took place during the Roman Empire. They argue that all the events described in Revelation belong exclusively to the first century when the church was being battered by emperor worship and persecution. All the prophecies in the book are believed to have been fulfilled with the fall of Jerusalem in AD 70, or at least with the fall of Rome in AD 476. The difficulty with this view is that Christ had not returned by these dates, yet his second coming is the book's climax and destination.

p 1583 • Others hold that these events began to unfold with the inception of the church and will continue as the seals are opened, one by one, until the consummation of history. Revelation is then treated as a forecast of world history from Christ's ascension on. Different passages have been identified as referring to Charlemagne, the French Revolution, various Roman Catholic popes, Mussolini, the European Union and so on. There are enormous dis agreements, however, about who equals what. There is also the problem that all these historical interpretations change from age to age, and that they are invariably Eurocentric.

- Still others believe that none of the seals have yet been opened, and that they will only be opened in the final hour of tribulation, just before the return of Christ. They read chapters 4–22 as a guide to what will happen just before and after Christ's return. The problem with this view is that it robs the book of Revelation of its relevance to the readers of John's day for whom it was written.

- Others argue that Revelation is not concerned with historical events in any particular era of church history, but deals with timeless principles in the war between good and evil. The strength of the view is that it recognizes the universal application of Christ's message to the churches, but it overlooks the fact that Revelation was specifically and clearly written to the existing churches of the first century.

- Finally, there is the 'apocalyptic' position, which sees Revelation as focusing on the suffering and persecution of God's people in light of the totality of human history. Since the casting down of Satan to earth, God's creation and his people have been targets of Satan's attacks, and this situation will continue until the second coming of Christ. Writers of apocalypses move backward and forward in human history, and so the disasters recorded in Revelation (seals, trumpets and bowls) should not be squeezed into an artificial chronology.

This last position is the one adopted in this commentary. Revelation is an apocalypse and must be read, studied and interpreted by the rules of that genre. Thus John's account of the seals (and trumpets and bowls) must be read as a working out in detail of the apocalyptic idea that the second coming of Christ will be preceded by periodic historical disasters, which will affect the whole present order in one way or another.

Although John is confident that the Lord Jesus Christ will soon come back and bring ultimate deliverance from this evil world and judgment on it, he does not want to delude his Christian readers with hopes that may be premature. Nothing in the book is more remarkable than the grim honesty with which the writer faces the situation before him. Seeing believers persecuted, he warns them that they must expect periods of sorrow and desolation just as God's people of previous generations did. And in the midst of all suffering, they should remain faithful to God. He encourages them to face martyrdom with endurance and with the anticipation of joining fellow-martyrs already in the eternal presence of God. Behind the mysteries and the judgments of life on earth, there is the directing hand of the eternal, all-powerful and all-knowing God.

6:1–2 Act II, Scene 1: The rider on the white horse

With the opening of the seals, the scene shifts from heaven to events on earth. A pattern emerges, with a rider on a horse appearing as each of the first four seals is broken. The first to appear is a victorious rider on a *white horse* (**6:2**). Some commentators have identified the rider as Jesus Christ, but the problem with this view is that since the Lamb is the one opening the seals in heaven, he cannot also be one of the riders. Moreover, theologically it would be inappropriate to have an angelic being, a creature, command Christ, the Creator, to do things (6:1). It is thus more likely that this rider, like the riders on the other three horses, is a symbol of the antichrist and the forces of evil and destruction. He may be contrasted with 'Faithful and True', the different rider on a white horse who appears in 19:11–16 and who 'judges and makes war' with justice. The rider in 6:2 is neither faithful nor true, and he wages war simply for the sake of conquest.

While the vision in 6:2 would be sobering for first-century believers, they could take courage in knowing that the Lamb had, for his own beneficent ends, permitted their suffering. So they could trust that despite the seeming victory of the evil one (in their case, through the Roman Empire), they were conquerors in Christ the victor, even if they faced martyrdom (17:14).

6:3–4 Act II, Scene 2: The rider on the red horse

The second horse is more sinister. He rides on a *fiery red* steed whose colour symbolizes slaughter (**6:4**; 2 Kgs 3:22–23). Its colour matches that of the dragon, the devil that persecutes the woman in 12:3, but is ultimately destroyed. First-century Christians may have been reminded of Nero's slaughter of Christians, the martyrdom of Antipas (2:13), or those slain under Domitian's persecutions. But other Christians will know of other slaughters.

6:5–6 Act II, Scene 3: The rider on the black horse

The opening of the third seal heralds the rider on the *black horse* (**6:5**), a colour also used to describe the conditions when the sixth seal is opened and the sun turns black (6:12). The rider holds *a pair of scales.* Elsewhere in the NT this term is translated as 'yoke', and is used metaphorically of a burden laid upon a person: like slavery (Gal 5:1; 1 Tim 6:1), some religious requirements (Acts 15:10), or of the 'yoke' of Christ, which is 'easy and light' (Matt 11:29–30). p 1584 Thus while the reference here may be to the scales used for weighing wheat, it is equally possible that it is a metaphor for subjugation to the forces of death-dealing hunger. The prices given for wheat and barley in **6:6** are exceedingly high and may reflect shortages.

6:7–8 Act II, Scene 4: The rider on the pale horse

The fourth seal reveals a rider on a *pale horse,* who is given the name *Death and Hades* (**6:8**). He probably represents death by pestilence or plague. While some may have died of plague in John's time, it is likely that this vision includes all pestilences that have already taken place (for example, in Egypt at the time of the exodus), and those that will take place throughout human history (including HIV/AIDS). As already stated, looking both backward and forward in human history is one of the characteristics of apocalyptic literature.

6:9–11 Act II, Scene 5: The prayer of the martyrs

The fifth seal changes the pattern, and we no longer see horsemen, but rather martyred saints under the altar crying out for justice upon those who killed them (**6:9–10**). They are told to wait a little longer till their fellow servants are also killed (**6:11**). These martyrs are referred to as 'all who have been killed on the earth' (18:24); 'all who refused to worship the image [of the beast and were] killed' (13:15); and 'those who had been beheaded because of their testimony for Jesus' (20:4). These martyred saints are now in heaven (2 Cor 5:6, 8).

Revelation does not dwell on how a loving God can allow so much suffering and even martyrdom. The book leaves us with the problem of Christian suffering, trials and Satan's activities, but encourages us to recognize that God is the one in control, and allows suffering to happen in this life.

6:12–17 Act II, Scene 6: Cosmic catastrophes

After the Lamb has broken the sixth seal, John witnesses certain signs heralding the imminent Day of the Lord (**6:12–14**; see Isa 2:12–21; 13:9–13; Jer 4:23–26; Joel 2:31; 3:15; Zeph 1:14–18; Matt 24:29). The scene in these verses, whether taken literally or figuratively, is one of catastrophes for all the inhabitants of the earth, regardless of their wealth or social class (**6:15–17**). The plea of the people for the rocks and mountains to fall on them occurs in Hosea in the context of God's judgment (6:16; Hos 10:8). Jesus predicted the same reaction from the inhabitants of Jerusalem when God's judgment would fall on them (Luke 23:30). In Revelation, God's wrath on all who refuse to repent of their sinful ways is presented as a past, present and future historical reality (Rom 1:18–25; 2:5). The Bible is consistent in depicting God's punishment of evil and sin from the beginning of human history until its consummation.

7:1–17 First interlude: The sealing of God's people

Between seals six and seven is the first interlude in the drama. In contrast to the awful scenes of the wrath of God portrayed in chapter 6, chapter 7 is a description of the sealing of God's people. It starts with a vision of *four angels standing at the four corners of the earth* (**7:1**). We should not understand this as a statement about the shape of the earth but as an assurance that the four angels watch over the whole world, and none of it is beyond their control. Their function is to hold back *the four winds of the earth* to prevent harmful winds from blowing *on the land or on the sea or on any tree.* The 'winds' may be another way of referring to the four horsemen of the first four seals (6:1–8), for in Zechariah four horses are explicitly interpreted as 'the four spirits [literally 'winds'] of heaven' (Zech 6:5; see also Isa 19:1; 66:15). Whereas Zechariah associates the winds with heaven,

stressing their subjection to God in heaven, John refers to them as *winds of the earth* because their destructive activity is connected with the earth. Winds are a natural symbol of destruction (Jer 4:11–12; 49:36).

As is typical of apocalyptic literature, this vision takes us back to answer the question, What is the fate of believers during the terrible happenings described in chapter 6? The answer to the question is revealed in the vision of *another angel coming up from the east* (**7:2**). The east is where the day dawns and light is first seen, and thus it often symbolizes a source of blessing. The Garden of Eden was located in the east (Gen 2:8), it was from this direction that the glory came to the temple (Ezek 43:2) and the wise men who came with the news that the Christ was born came from the east (Matt 2:1–2).

The angel has *the seal of the living God.* A seal was basically a mark of ownership (Eph 1:13–14). Here it marks those sealed as God's and thus preserves them from the destruction that will fall on the world (6:1–8; Exod 12:23; Ezek 9:1–6). God's own bear his mark elsewhere in this book (9:4; 14:1; 22:4). This angel shouts to the other four and commands them not to hurt earth, sea or trees until God's servants are sealed on their foreheads (**7:3**). Even when facing persecution and martyrdom, believers can be certain that no plague or persecution can destroy them spiritually but that they will live in God's presence for ever because they are his own possession (3:10; Rom 8:35–39).

The seal on God's servants can be contrasted with the mark of the beast, which identifies those who bear it as beast worshippers and thus objects of God's irreversible wrath (13:16–17; 14:9–11). By contrast, those who have the seal of God are his servants, who worship him with utter devotion and are the objects of his abiding grace. They will not be deluded by the beast (19:20).

God's restraint of the forces of destruction is an important thread that runs through the book of Revelation. Every moment of earth's history is made to serve God's redeeming p 1585 purpose. The four winds cannot blow and vent their rage as they like, but only as they serve the purposes of God.

John hears the number of those permanently sealed: *144,000 from all the tribes of Israel* (**7:4**). But who are these people? Commentators disagree about whether the 144,000 and the great multitude referred to in 7:9 are the same or different groups, whether the former refers to a literal or spiritual Israel, and whether either or both groups are composed of martyrs. There is little evidence to decide these points, and we must be guided by our understanding of the book of Revelation as a whole. As we have already pointed out, Revelation is an apocalyptic book and not simply an account of the end times.

The problem with interpreting the 144,000 as Jewish believers is that the *great multitude* in **7:9a** also represents those who are saved, but it is said to be composed of people *from every nation, tribe, people and language.* Why would this multitude be saved without sealing, while only the Jews are sealed for protection?

Others argue that the word 'Israel' in 7:4 refers to all believers, regardless of their nationality. They point out that Abraham is 'the father of all who believe' (Rom 4:11), and that believers are thus his children (Gal 3:7) and constitute 'the Israel of God' (Gal 6:16). Believers are the true Jews (2:9; 3:9; see also Rom 2:28–29), the ones God calls his 'very own' people (Titus 2:14) and 'the circumcision' (Phil 3:3).

It could be argued that the specific reference to the twelve tribes in **7:5–8** means that these people are literally of Jewish descent. However, John speaks of the new Jerusalem as the spiritual home of all believers, and it has on its gates the names of the twelve tribes (21:12). There is thus good reason for seeing the 144,000 as all believers. This number is made up of twelve times 12,000, a number that combines the 'twelve' that represents the church (Matt 19:28; Jas 1:1) and the thousand that represents a great number.

This great multitude 'from every nation, tribe, people and language' are clothed in the *white robes* (**7:9b**) that symbolize salvation. 'White' is also the colour of victory, while the *palm branches* they hold were often emblems of triumph (Matt 21:5–8). They are identified by the angel as those *who have come out of the great tribulation* (**7:14**) and who now worship in God's *temple* (**7:15**). God will *spread his tent over them,* meaning that his presence will be amongst them (Exod 40:34–38). Never again will these people endure torment (**7:16**). They will enjoy the supreme protection of the living God himself (Ps 91:1–2). The graciousness of God to those who follow him is brought out in **7:17**, a verse that speaks of a tenderness and comfort not often seen in this book.

8:1 Act II, Scene 7: Silence in heaven

John makes effective use of the element of suspense. After each set of six calamities he withholds the seventh, with a dark hint that when it does come, it will be overwhelming (**8:1**; 10:7; 16:17).

The opening of the seventh seal causes silence in heaven (8:1). The seemingly inevitable process is interrupted, and the pause enables reflection on what is happening, even in heaven. Sometimes silence and reflection are an appropriate response in the midst of the tumult of life. The words of a Shona proverb from Zimbabwe apply here: 'What we cannot speak about we must pass over in silence.' Sometimes, it is tempting to try to explain and justify everything we read in Revelation, when in reality the right response should be silence, awe, fear and dread.

8:2–11:18 Act III: Vision of the Seven Angels—Announcement of God's Wrath

Stage Setting: The stage shows an open sanctuary. Prominently displayed are the altars of sacrifice and of incense. An angel carries a golden censer of incense toward the former as the curtain rises (**8:3**). Before the throne are also seven angels, each with a trumpet in hand (**8:2**). Once again, we are in a worship setting, this time one where the prayers of the saints are heard and acted on (**8:4–6**).

Acts III and IV parallel acts V and VI, and give more details of the events first presented in act II, scene 6. Acts III and V show how believers weather the storm throughout human history, while acts IV and VI depict the failure of non-believers to withstand God's judgment. The events described here as initiated by trumpets may be the same as those initiated by the opening of the seals since their targets are identical (compare 6:1–8; 8:7–12). Similar catastrophes are described in 6:12–17, in this act, and in 16:2–9 in act V, scenes 1–4. Ever since the casting out of the devil from heaven, life on earth has been characterized by cosmic catastrophes and human suffering (Rom 8:20–22), all leading toward the day of final consummation (Isa 2:10–21; 13:9–13; Joel 2:31; 3:15; Zeph 1:14–18; Matt 24:29). In Revelation, God's wrath is presented as both a present historical reality as well as a future judgment.

The first four trumpets (8:7–12) affect four areas of God's creation: earth, sea, fresh water and the heavens (compare 14:7). These are limited judgments aimed at producing repentance (9:20–21). In general, it will be noted that only *a third* of anything is affected. The plagues mentioned in scenes 1, 2 and 4 find their origin in the account of the exodus (Exod 9:23–26; 7:20–21; 10:21). p 1586

8:5–7 Act III, Scene 1: Hail and fire fall on the earth

This scene is preceded by *peals of thunder, rumblings, flashes of lightning and an earthquake* (**8:5**). The first angel blows his trumpet, and *hail and fire mixed with blood* rain on earth (**8:7**). A third of the earth, including a third of its plant life, is consumed. Indeed, all the green grass is burnt off. Revelation's grim picture of ecological catastrophe might seem to underline the belief of some that Christianity is not merely world-denying but also indifferent to the cosmos, which is destined for destruction. There are hints in passages like 11:18 and 19:2, however, that the destruction of the earth is a consequence of the sinful behaviour of humankind (Gen 3; Rom 8:20–21).

8:8–9 Act III, Scene 2: A mountain cast into the sea

The second angel blows his trumpet, and *something like a huge mountain, all ablaze* falls into the sea (**8:8**). As a result, a third part of the sea turns bloody, a third of the creatures living in the sea die, and a third of the ships on the sea are destroyed.

8:10–11 Act III, Scene 3: A star falls on rivers and springs

The third angel blows his trumpet and there falls from the sky *a great star burning like a torch.* (**8:10**; see Isa 14:12). For John, a *star* means an angel (1:20; 9:1–2). Whereas the other plagues do not directly affect people, in this passage, the fallen angel is identified with *Wormwood,* a poisonous plant. Its fall affects a third of all rivers and springs of water. So, a third of all waters are poisoned and many creatures die (Jer 9:15; 23:15).

8:12–13 Act III, Scene 4: The sun, moon and stars darken

The fourth angel blows his trumpet, and a third part of the sun, of the moon and of the stars are affected. The result is that daytime is diminished by a third and nighttime likewise.

The effects of the first four trumpet blasts have been terrible, but the effects of the next three will be worse, as they are introduced as 'Woes' (**8:13**). This warning to all people is the negative side of the gospel message (Luke 6:24–26), intended to bring all people to repentance (9:20–21), and is the final demonstration of God's desire to see all people saved (1 Tim 2:3–4).

9:1–12 Act III, Scene 5 (Woe 1): The Abyss is opened

In 7:1–17 we saw the multitude of those who had 'a seal on [their] foreheads'. But we had not yet been told the nature of the 'great tribulation' (7:14) through which they had to pass. John begins to depict this for us here. It is to be a period during which an angel (the *star* of **9:1–2** will permit the release from *the Abyss* of an immoral destructive power, under its leader *Abaddon* or *Apollyon,*

names that both mean 'Destroyer' (**9:11**). Spiritual warfare rages from the time Satan or the devil, the destroyer, was thrown out of heaven until the second coming of Christ.

The *locusts* described in 9:3–10 (like the frogs in 16:13) symbolize a demonic force. The imagery of an army of locusts advancing like a cloud, darkening the heavens and sounding like the rattle of chariots, goes back to Joel's vision of an army of locusts that came on Israel as a judgment from God (Joel 1:6; 2:4–10). This, together with the fact that they do not eat plants (**9:4a**), shows that these are no ordinary locusts. Nor are they simply a physical plague, like the locust of Moses' or Joel's day. What these locust-like beings attack is the human spirit. They inflict a non-fatal injury on the beast worshippers who do not have the seal of God on their foreheads (**9:4b**). The locusts are demonic or evil forces (as with the first four trumpets) out of the Abyss from whom the true people of God are spiritually protected. So severe is the torment they inflict that their victims will seek death (**9:5–6**; see Job 3:21; Jer 8:3; Hos 10:8).

This graphic picture of the immoral influences of demonic forces that are constantly at work also reminds us of the limitations of the power of evil. The demons can exercise only the power that is allowed (*given*—9:5) them by God (see 1 Sam 16:14). On this occasion they have power to torment, but not to kill (Job 1:12; 2:6). The evil of the locusts never gets out of hand, but is under God's sovereign control, and the period of its activity is limited to *five months* (**9:10**), that is, a very short time in the light of eternity.

9:13–21 Act III, Scene 6 (Woe 2): Release of four angels

The action of this scene is set in motion by *a voice coming from … the golden altar* of incense (**9:13**; 8:3). The exactness of the time element suggested by the reference to the *hour and day and month and year* (**9:15**) indicates that the entire drama is within the plan of God (Mark 13:32). The four angels here are those who stood at the four corners of earth in 7:1, where they were presented as the guardians of the earth's four winds. Here they are presented as leaders of a vast army (**9:16**).

These horrific images of destruction look back to the exodus plagues (Exod 7–10) and also forward to eschatological destruction depicted by John in 16:9. The exodus motif that is so prevalent in Revelation drives home the point that even after such devastating plagues, the rest of the people do not repent (**9:20–21**). The people described here respond like Pharaoh. They continue in their idolatrous and rebellious ways. The need for repentance is an insistent theme in the letters to the churches (2:5, 16, 21–22; 3:3, 19). It is as if humanity is brought face to face with the full horror of the wickedness it has created, and yet will do nothing to prevent the consequences of its actions. p 1587

10:1–11:13 Second interlude: The little scroll, two witnesses

As was the case between the scenes of the sixth and seventh seals (7:1–17), John inserts an interlude between the sixth and seventh trumpets to provide reassurance to the faithful that they will not be spiritually destroyed by the eschatological woes. This interlude contains two complementary visions: one, an account of a call to John to prophesy (10:1–11) and the other an account of the witness of two figures who prophesy for a time before being killed by the beast from the Abyss (11:1–13).

10:1–11 THE LITTLE SCROLL For the first and last time the seer is drawn away from his observer's corner to the very centre of the stage. This is akin to bringing a member of the audience on stage to act in a play. In **10:1–2**, John sees a *mighty angel* coming down and standing with one foot on the sea and the other on land. The physical description of the angel owes much to Daniel 10:4–6 and the scene draws also upon the vision in Daniel 12 in which two angels appear to Daniel, 'one on this bank of the river and one on the opposite bank' (Dan 12:5). The angel speaks like a roaring lion, causing the seven thunders to break forth. The seven thunders deliver a message that John is about to write down when he is told to *seal up* the message, that is, to keep it secret (**10:4**; 1:19; 22:10; Dan 8:26; 12:4, 9). This refusal to reveal the message of the seven thunders is a way of saying that God's purposes and plans are not all revealed because God is beyond full human comprehension.

Like the contents of the sealed scroll in chapter 5, what the seven thunders utter remains a *mystery* (**10:7**) and thus forms no part of this book of prophecy, which is very much a public text (22:10). However, this mystery will be fulfilled after the seventh trumpet is blown, marking 11:15 as a crucial moment in the narrative. The angel reveals that the mystery which God had proclaimed by *his servants, the prophets* is moving to its climax (10:7; compare Dan 9:6; Amos 3:7; Zech 1:6).

The angel then raises his right hand to heaven and swears by *him who lives forever and ever* (**10:5–6**; Dan 12:7) that there will be no more delay. The time for the fulfilment of God's purposes is near. Soon God will act decisively and will triumph over the evil forces. The cry 'How long?' of saints facing persecution and martyrdom would be answered (Pss 6:3; 13:1; 94:3).

For John, *eating* the scroll is a reinforcement of his commission as prophet. The *scroll is sweet as honey,* but makes his *stomach sour* (**10:9–10**). This scroll, like that of chapters 4–5, contains God's plan for all creation, which John is to make known. *Eating* the scroll is symbolic of taking in the message, of 'consuming' God's word (see Ezek 3:1–2), so that God's message is now John's message. The scroll is both sour and sweet, because it contains judgment and mercy, punishment and blessing. A close parallel with this scroll is found in Daniel 12. There Daniel is told to keep the 'scroll' or 'book' sealed 'until the time of the end' (Dan 12:4). Now, however, the book is unsealed because there can be no more delay (10:6). The long-awaited time of God's vindication has arrived.

11:1–13 THE TWO WITNESSES John is next commanded to measure the *temple of God and the altar* (**11:1**). In the Bible, measuring has many metaphorical meanings. It may refer to the promise of restoration and rebuilding, with an emphasis on extension or enlargement (Jer 31:38–39; Zech 1:16), or it may mark something for destruction (2 Sam 8:2; 2 Kgs 21:13; Isa 28:17; Lam 2:8; Amos 7:7–9). John's *measuring* of the temple of God, the altar and the worshippers seems to be similar to the *sealing* of believers that protects them from spiritual destruction (7:1–8). Similarly, in 21:15–17 John depicts an angel measuring the heavenly city with a golden rod, apparently to mark it and its inhabitants off from spiritual harm and defilement. As with the sealing, the measuring does not symbolize preservation from physical harm, but the guarantee that none of the faithful worshipers of God will perish even though they may suffer physical death at the hand of the beast (13:7).

Ezekiel was told to 'describe the temple to the people of Israel that they may be ashamed of their sins' (Ezek 43:10). The elaborate description and measurement in Ezekiel 40–48 indicate the glory and holiness of God in Israel's midst and convict Israel of their sin of defiling his sanctuary. Ezekiel was instructed to exclude from the sanctuary 'the foreigners uncircumcised in heart and flesh' (Ezek 44:5–9). Likewise, John is here told not to measure the *outer court* (**11:2**). Those who do not worship the true God are to be excluded from spiritual security and God's blessing. Prophetic

ministry calls for a clear separation between those who live for God and those who have defiled themselves with the idolatry of the beast.

The focus now moves to the persecution of the *two witnesses* who represent the believing community in every age (**11:3**). The imagery here is taken from Zechariah 4. The two witnesses are referred to as *two olive trees* or *two lampstands* full of oil, that is, God's Spirit (**11:4**). They witness in the courtyard outside the sanctuary or in the great city, *figuratively called Sodom and Egypt* where *their Lord was crucified* (**11:8**, the only reference to the means of Christ's death in the whole book). In other words, they witness in the evil world, the place of rebellion and persecution.

These witnesses have the same powers as Moses and Elijah (**11:6**; see Exod 7:17–19; 1 Kgs 17:1) and their ministry is variously described as testimony or prophecy (11:3, 6–7). Chapters 10 and 11 issue a direct call to believers to participate in God's ministry as prophets rather than merely as passive spectators. In the midst of superhuman forces, the church as a whole has a prophetic role.

The fate of the two witnesses, who are killed by the beast who *comes up from the Abyss* (**11:7**; 9:11; 13:2; Dan 7:3), p 1588 reminds us that throughout history God's people are not spared from suffering or tribulation (see 7:14). Prophets, as witnesses of God can expect suffering and even death. Whenever Christians resist evil, they will come under pressure to conform. If they refuse to conform, they may find themselves the target of the anger and retribution of those who seek to maintain the world as it is. Thus the people to whom the witnesses were commanded to prophesy rejoice when they see the corpses lying unburied (**11:9–10**). Those who scorn them are referred to as *inhabitants of the earth,* a phrase with negative connotations (11:10; 6:10; 8:13; 13:8, 12, 14; 17:2, 8).

However, conquest by the beast cannot overcome the true conquest of the Lamb, Jesus Christ. The two witnesses are brought back to life by the *breath of life from God* (**11:11**). That action is followed by a great voice from heaven telling them *Come up here* (**11:12**), the same command that was given to John by the voice 'like a trumpet' (4:1; 10:4; 12:10; 14:13). The ascent of the witnesses to heaven in a cloud echoes the ascension of their Lord (Acts 1:9), and their enemies see them vindicated. A *severe earthquake* follows (**11:13a**; 6:12; 8:5; 16:18), similar to the one which occurred at the resurrection of Jesus (Matt 28:2). The people respond to the earthquake by giving *glory to the God of heaven* (**11:13b**), although they do not truly turn to him. At this point, the second woe has passed.

11:14–18 Act III, Scene 7: Worship in heaven

The absence of any specific mention of the third woe, other than the statement that it *is coming soon* (**11:14**), may be an indication that the final consummation is still awaited. The readers stand in the midst of the drama of human history. It is partly complete, and we are, as it were, offered a preview of the ending. In the midst of the trials and tribulations, we await the climax. We can only watch, wait, witness and worship and not be led astray (Matt 25:1–13; Mark 13:9, 32–37).

The sounding of the seventh trumpet is also related to the events that surround the final consummation of history. But to declare all this now would mean the end of the drama. So what follows next is praise of God by the twenty-four elders. Act III closes as it began, with a picture of the redeemed at prayer as they face the thought of persecution in the last times (**11:15–18**). Praying is one way of staying focused on God when we are going through difficult times.

11:19–15:4 Act IV: Vision of the Church Triumphant

Stage Setting: The setting is like those in acts II and III, except that the sanctuary of God, which is in heaven, is now wholly opened to view. As a result, the ark of the covenant within the sanctuary becomes visible, including its cover, which was regarded as God's throne. Whereas act III the worshipping believers were at the centre of the stage, the view of the ark shows that act IV will deal with God's answer to his people's prayers.

In this act, we are presented with the great conflict between the forces of good and evil, order and chaos, obedience and disobedience, and loyalty and rebellion throughout human history. Evil powers have always rebelled against God's authority and attempted to thwart his purposes. The suffering of the believers of John's day was not an isolated incident. Their struggle was simply another chapter in the ancient story of chaos versus order, obedience versus disobedience, rebellion versus loyalty. God's prophets were persecuted (Jer 38), and those who announced the first coming of Christ were murdered (Acts 7:52–53). John reminds his readers that by their patient endurance and faithful witness, they are contributing to the ultimate overthrow and defeat of the powers of evil.

In acts I, II, III and V, John primarily uses numbers to mark out each scene (for example, there are seven letters, seven seals, seven trumpets and seven bowls). But in acts IV, VI and VII, each new scene is introduced with the words 'I heard' or 'I saw' or 'He showed me' or 'appeared'. A similar approach is used in Ezekiel, Daniel and other apocalyptic literature, but it is not found in any other NT book. Failure to take note of this simple but crucial literary device will result in loss of direction in reading and understanding the rest of the drama.

11:19–13:1a Act IV, Scene 1: The woman and the dragon

John hears *flashes of lightning, rumblings, peals of thunder, an earthquake and a great hailstorm* (**11:19**). Though the sanctuary has stood open on the stage ever since act II, this is the first time that it has occupied such a prominent position. It is not strange that we have not yet been able to look into this holy place. In the OT, only the current high priest was permitted to look upon the ark of the covenant, once a year. It is extraordinary that John should permit us to gaze within this sanctuary at all, and even more so that he should expose it on his cosmic stage. But through the work of Jesus Christ, 'the curtain of the temple was torn in two from top to bottom' (Matt 27:51), and there is now 'a new and living way opened through the curtain' (Heb 10:20) to the throne of God.

12:1–6 THE WOMAN, HER SON AND THE DRAGON In **12:1** John speaks of the appearance of a great sign in heaven, a pregnant woman *clothed with the sun* (see 10:1), with *the moon under her feet* and a *crown* with *twelve stars* on her head (see 1:16). She is crying out in labour pains (**12:2**; see Isa 66:7). The word used to describe her agony is the same word used to describe the experience of the inhabitants of the world as God's judgment comes upon them (9:5; 14:10–11; 18:7, 10, p 1589 15; see also Luke 21:23). Thus the woman is not immune from suffering.

The *male child* to whom she gives birth is clearly the Lord Jesus Christ, for he is the one *who will rule all the nations with an iron sceptre* (**12:5**; 2:27; 19:15; Gen 49:9–10; Ps 2:9).

Another sign appears alongside the first (12:3–6): a great dragon, who is identified as Satan in 12:9 and whose influence on earth is depicted in chapter 13. The dragon is *red* (6:4) and its *seven heads, ten horns and seven crowns* resemble the beast in 13:1 (**12:3**; 5:6; Dan 7:7). Its *tail* sweeps *a*

third of the stars to earth (**12:4a**; 6:13; 8:12; Dan 8:10). The dragon stands before the woman, echoing the description of the Lamb and the great multitude that stand in God's presence. But the dragon is not worshipping but threatening to devour the woman's child as soon as it is born (**12:4b;** see Gen 4:7). The dragon fails in his attempt to kill the child, who is snatched away, just as the Lord Jesus Christ was taken up to heaven at his ascension.

The woman is pursued by the dragon and she flees into the *desert* (**12:6**), the place where John will later be taken to see Babylon, represented as a very different woman (17:3–4). This desert should not be seen as a harsh and forbidding place. It is a place that God has prepared for the woman, where she will be *taken care of* (12:6). It is unclear who will take care of her. If it is angels, then there is a parallel to the care Jesus Christ received during his temptation in the desert (Mark 1:13). Hagar, too, found relief in the desert after being ill-treated by Sarah (Gen 16:7; 21:4–19), and the prophet Elijah's life was sustained by God when he fled into the desert to escape Jezebel (1 Kgs 19:1–9).

The flight into the desert also reminds us of Joseph and Mary's fleeing to Egypt with the infant Jesus (Matt 2:13–15). But this woman does not represent Mary specifically but rather the whole community of God's people. Throughout their history, the people of God have lived as 'aliens and strangers' in the desert of a fallen and hostile world, while their true home is in heaven (Heb 11:13–16). Yet while they are in the desert, God continues to nurture them and supply their every need 'according to his glorious riches in Christ Jesus' (Phil 4:19) God never forsakes his own people.

The woman is enabled to survive for 1260 days, otherwise defined in 12:14 as 'a time, times and half a time' and in 13:5 as 'forty-two months', that is, for a short period in comparison with the limitless eternity of peace and freedom that will follow in the new heaven and earth.

12:7–12 WAR IN HEAVEN War breaks out in heaven as Michael and his angels fight against the dragon (**12:7**). This is the only reference to the archangel Michael in the NT, apart from Jude 9. In Daniel, Michael is the angelic protector of the people of God (Dan 10:13–21; 12:1), a role that is assumed by the ascended Christ in the NT (Rom 8:34; 1 John 2:1).

This war, though waged in heaven, will have an enormous effect on human history. The dragon and his angels did not prevail and there was no longer any place for them in heaven. As a result, the dragon, *that ancient serpent called the devil or Satan* was cast down to earth with his angels (**12:8–9a**; Gen 3:1, 14). Historically, this speaks of Satan's fall from his former state.

In the Bible, Satan is portrayed as the arch-enemy of God and his people. His enmity underlies the description of him here as the one *who leads the whole world astray* and *the accuser of our brothers* (**12:9b**, **10**). His role as deceiver has already been alluded to in the description of Jezebel (2:20–24). There a local church was threatened with deceit; here it is the whole world (13:14; 19:20; 20:3, 8, 10). As we shall see in chapter 13, deceit is a characteristic of the beast, which works through the political and religious (non-Christian) systems of any society.

Believers can easily fall into Satan's traps, and he is eager to accuse them *before our God day and night* (12:10), in contrast to the day-and-night praise of the four living creatures and the martyrs (4:8; 7:15). In giving Satan this role, Revelation is reflecting an OT understanding of Satan as a heavenly prosecutor (Job 1:6–12; 2:1–7; Zech 3:1). In the NT, Satan, as the 'prince of this world' tempts believers to sin and disobey God (John 12:31; 1 Pet 5:8). He even tempted Jesus Christ to sin during his earthly life and ministry (Matt 4:1–11).

But powerful as this enemy is, he has been defeated by Christ at the cross. Believers have overcome him *by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony,* and because *they did not love their lives so much as to shrink from death* (**12:11b**). The Lamb's blood is linked with the victory of the brethren (**12:11a**; see 1:5; 5:9; 19:13). The *word of their testimony* is in harmony with that of the Lamb (2:13) and provokes the same kind of response (11:7).

A voice is heard in heaven announcing that now *the salvation and the power and the kingdom* have come (12:10). The kingdom is now seen to belong to God and the rule to his Messiah (Dan 7:14; Matt 28:18). In 20:1–4, this kingdom is also related to the binding of Satan 'for a thousand years'.

Because of what Christ has done (**12:12a**), and because his victory extends to the believers, the voice calls on the *heavens* and those who live there to rejoice. The term 'heaven' is found fifty-two times in Revelation, but this is the only place it is used as a plural. Heaven speaks of a permanent home (John 14:1–3; 2 Cor 5:6, 8; Phil 1:21).

While the inhabitants of heaven are the ones called to rejoicing, those on earth whose citizenship is in heaven can rejoice too. Although they suffer grievous troubles on earth, their troubles are temporary and triumph is already being savoured in heaven. But for now there is *woe* for them on *earth* and *sea* (**12:12b**). The devil has come down in great anger, knowing that only a little *time* remains before the p 1591 second coming. The Greek word translated 'time' carries the implication of 'a suitable time' (see 1:3; 11:18). Not much time remains suitable for the activities of the evil one. The righteous do not suffer persecution because Satan is stronger than God but because he is doing all the harm he can while he can, before God stops him. Satan will not be able to do this for much longer. He is a defeated enemy who has limited time.

12:13–13:1a WAR ON EARTH Furious about his failure to devour the woman's male child and about his defeat by Michael, the dragon (Satan) directs his wrath against the woman herself and the rest of her offspring (**12:13**). This image represents the conflict of good and evil throughout human history. It is an account (in metaphorical language) of the persecution and suffering that has been inflicted on God's people since the fall of the devil to earth.

This passage contains the last mention of the woman who first appeared in 12:6. Here, she simultaneously represents Mary the mother of Jesus, Israel from whom the Messiah came, and the people of God of all ages whose descendants are still being persecuted today.

After giving birth, the woman had fled into the desert to be nourished there. She reappears in these verses, but only to be pursued by the dragon. Thus the defeat of Satan is sandwiched between the two parts of the vision of the woman clothed with the sun. Satan is defeated in heaven and cannot conquer the woman and her offspring on earth in spite of repeated, vigorous persecution. The woman is given *the two wings of a great eagle* (**12:14**; Exod 19:4; Isa 40:31) and escapes again to the desert, where she is taken care of (see 12:6). The wider reference of this symbolic language is to the sanctuary the Lord himself provides for his people throughout human history.

The dragon, now referred to as *the serpent,* pours *water like a river* from his mouth *to sweep her away with the torrent* (**12:15**; compare 9:17–19; 11:5; 16:13). She is protected from *the flood* when the earth comes to help her and swallows the water (**12:16**). The earth rises up, as it were, to aid the woman, against those who destroy the earth (11:18). The devil's anger with the woman leads him *to make war against the rest of her offspring* (**12:17**).

John's vision ends abruptly with Satan standing on the seashore on the brink of the Abyss, that place from which the beast will rise to try the faithfulness of the saints of God (11:7). p 1590

PERSECUTION

The church in Africa has long been familiar with persecution. As long ago as the third century AD, the African church father Tertullian was moved to declare that 'the blood of the martyrs is the seed of the church'. The persecution has continued in modern times in countries like Uganda under President Idi Amin, in Chad under President Tombalbaye, and is still continuing in countries like Ethopia and Eritrea. It flares up sporadically in other countries too. Those who convert from Islam to Christianity often face severe discrimination and sometimes even death.

The main aim of persecution is not to destroy the individuals who are persecuted but to eliminate the faith they profess. Persecutors attempt to force Christians to deny their faith in Jesus Christ in order to dislodge Christ from their lives. Thus the real target of persecution is Jesus Christ (Acts 9:4).

Persecution of believers has a long history. The first recorded example in the OT is the killing of Abel by his brother Cain, which is an example of the struggle between the righteous and the unrighteous (Gen 4:3–8). Others who were persecuted include Joseph (Gen 39:19–20), David (1 Sam 18:9; Ps 119:87, 157, 161), Elijah (1 Kgs 19:1–3) and Jeremiah (Jer 26:10–11). Prophets who stood uncompromisingly for the truth sometimes paid with their lives (2 Chr 36:15–16). During the exile, Daniel, Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego were all tested severely for refusing to worship a heathen king (Dan 3 and 6). Readiness to accept suffering and even death for the truth has been carried forward from Judaism to Christianity.

Persecution Predicted

Jesus repeatedly predicted that his followers would face hostility (Matt 5:10–12; 10:16–23, 34–36; Mark 10:29–30; Luke 6:26; 23:28–31). The reason is that they do not belong to the world but to the Kingdom of God (Matt 5:10–12; Mark 13:9–13; John 16:33). One cannot belong to both at the same time, for they are incompatible. The world does not know God (John 16:1–4; Acts 17:23; Rom 1:18–32) and hates Christ (John 15:20). We are thus rejected because we are not members of the same family; we do not share a common father.

Jesus not only expected his followers to be prepared to face persecution but was also prepared to face it himself. He set the example for those who follow him. As John 15:18–25 makes clear, if our Master endured persecution, why should we expect less?

In the Acts of the Apostles, we read of believers being imprisoned, beaten or killed for their faith (Acts 5:17–18, 40; 6:8–7:59). Persecution is also mentioned in the book of Revelation (Rev 1:9; 2:13; 6:9). But God promises that he will avenge the martyred (Rev

19:2). In the midst of persecution, the Christian's vocation is to endure, for through Christ victory is already won (John 16:33).

Persecution is an inescapable part of the true Christian's journey of faith. Yet when it comes, we often ask, "Why me, Lord"? Such questioning can lead to self-pity, doubting and complaining. This response blurs our ability to perceive God's purpose in allowing the adversity, because we are forgetting that God is sovereign. He has the right to rule the universe that he made for his own glory, and we are like clay in the potter's hands. Nothing either good or bad catches God by surprise (Isa 45:7). God can even turn bad circumstances around so that they work for our long-term good (Rom 8:28). Balak's attempt to get Balaam to curse Israel is a good example of this, for instead of curses the Israelites received blessings (Num 22, 23 and 24). No one can disrupt God's promise to his children.

Persecution Refines

James makes the point that persecution has a refining effect on the believer, just as fire purifies gold. Under persecution, our faith is put to the test. He reminds us that trials are inevitable, can take various forms and may arise when we least expect them. We are called to respond properly and to endure the suffering, which will produce fruit such as maturity and completeness in our Christian lives (Jas 1:2–8).

Christians should neither be surprised (John 15:20; 1 Pet 4:12) nor afraid (Isa 41:10–14) when persecuted. Instead they are to rejoice (Jas 1:2). It is a privilege to share in Christ's suffering (Matt 5:11; 1 Pet 4:13–16). Like the apostles, they should see suffering for him as a mark of honour (Acts 5:41) and pray for boldness in the face of persecution (Acts 4:24–30).

Believers are called to pray for their persecutors (Matt 5:44), and even bless them rather than wishing them evil (Rom 12:14). Those who are persecuted are to commit themselves to God (1 Pet 4:19) and rejoice in spite of their suffering (1 Pet 1:6). Their fellow believers are to pray for them (Acts 12:5) and expect great things to happen instead of doubting (Acts 12:15).

Above all, we should all remember that our adversary only attacks believers who are alive. Being persecuted is a sign that you are alive in Christ.

Elias M. Githuka

13:1b–10 Act IV, Scene 2: The beast from the sea

Scene 1 closed with a view of the dragon standing by the sea. He has been thrown from heaven to earth, and stands poised to unleash his fury against God's faithful believers. Scene 2 opens: *And I*

saw a beast coming out of the sea (**13:1a**). The sea, which will disappear in the new creation (21:1), is a symbol of chaos (Gen 1:2; Ps 104:7–9). The kingdoms of the world, representing satanic powers, are also described as beasts that come from the sea (Dan 7:3–7).

This beast is like the dragon in having *ten horns* representing power and *seven heads* (**13:1b**; 12:3) signifying the totality of the underworld's wisdom and understanding. The *ten crowns* speak of the dominion of satanic powers, and the *blasphemous name* on each head reveals this beast's opposition to God. John has made reference to it already in 11:7, where it is described as coming 'up from the Abyss' to fight the community of God. It thus seems that act IV is an elaboration of the events already described in scene 6 of act III.

It is very difficult to imagine an animal like the one John describes here. We need to remember that his aim is not to help us draw the beast but to convey an impression of something indescribably horrible. He uses the symbolism that is a common feature of apocalyptic literature and gives the beast the characteristics of the three beasts described in Daniel 7:4–6—a leopard, a bear and a lion (**13:2a**). In Daniel 7, these beasts represent various world empires, and John may have been thinking in these terms. But John does not see the beast as having any power of its own. The dragon gives it *his power and his throne and great authority* (**13:2b**), making it a formidable enemy.

John says that *one of the heads … seemed to have had a fatal wound, but the fatal wound had been healed* (**13:3**). John does not say how the beast received its wound, but in 13:14 we find that it was made *by the sword.* He does not even say whether it received the wound after it came to land or how it came to be healed. John's interest is in the fact that a wound that appeared to be mortal had been healed.

Certain features of John's description have led some to identify this head with the Emperor Nero and the beast with the Roman Empire. Nero committed suicide by stabbing himself in the neck, and a legend grew up that he had survived. Against this, it should be observed that the wound is only on one of the beast's heads in 13:3 but has become a wound of the whole beast in 13:12, 14. The self-inflicted wound of the rejected emperor was not a wound inflicted on the whole empire. Moreover, it is difficult to see how the legend about the healing of Nero's throat could have enhanced the authority of the beast or the dragon's war against the saints.

The word translated *fatal wound* is also significant. Elsewhere in Revelation it is translated as 'plague' and refers to a divinely inflicted judgment (9:18, 20; 11:6; 15:1; 16:9, 21; 18:4, 8; 21:9; 22:18). The *sword* in Revelation is a symbol of the divine judgment of the Messiah (1:16; 2:12, 16; 19:15, 21), except in 13:10 where a sword is used against the people of God. It is thus likely that John is not speaking of the sword that caused Nero's death but of the sword as the symbol of God's judgment that has delivered a death blow to the authority of the beast (and the dragon).

p 1592 This identification of the beast's enemy enables us to understand what event John might have in mind as delivering the death blow. In Revelation, the only conqueror of the beast and the dragon is the slain Lamb, together with his faithful saints (12:11; 19:19–21). The crucifixion, resurrection and exaltation of Jesus Christ dealt the death blow to the dragon and the beast (1:5; 5:9). This thought is paralleled by other NT passages (Luke 10:17–24; 11:14–22; John 12:31–33; Col 2:15). The wound is not a reference to Nero's wound but to Genesis 3:13–15, where God speaks of the serpent's head being bruised.

The same paradox found in chapter 12 also appears here in chapter 13. The dragon in chapter 12 is defeated and cast out of heaven, but he still has time and ability to wage a relentless war against

the people of God. Likewise, the beast here in chapter 13 has been dealt a fatal blow by the cross of Christ, and yet he still has time and ability (permitted by God) to wage spiritual warfare against the redeemed. He appears to be alive and in full command; his blasphemies increase (2 Tim 3:1–9). What the sea beast cannot accomplish, he commissions the earth beast to do (13:11–12.). All three, the dragon, the sea beast and the earth beast, though distinguishable, work together to achieve the same purpose: a) deceiving unbelievers so that they worship the dragon and the sea beast, and b) destroying all who oppose them.

There are numerous parallels between John's descriptions of the beast and of Jesus Christ. Both Christ and the beast wield swords; both have their names inscribed on the foreheads of their followers (13:16–14:1); both have horns (5:6; 13:1); both have authority; and both were given (by different authorities) power over every nation, tribe, people and language, as well as over the kings of the earth (1:5; 7:9; 13:7; 17:12). The beast is thus not the Roman Empire or any of its emperors but the great counterpart to Jesus Christ. This theological characterization is far more important than any identification of a specific historical figure.

References to people being manifestations of the antichrist in John's epistles (1 John 2:18, 22; 4:3; 2 John 7) and Paul's description of the coming 'man of lawlessness' (2 Thess 2:3–4, 8–9) have led some past and modern interpreters to conclude that some coming individual will be the antichrist. However, it seems likely that John is not pointing to one particular arch-enemy of God's people, whether in the past or in the future, but to an embodiment of evil that manifests itself in different people throughout human history. This is not to say that John would deny historical manifestations of this satanic reality; but it does prevent us from interpreting his imagery merely in terms of the Roman Empire or limiting it to any single present or future political or religious entity or individual.

The arrogant speech of the beast echoes that of the horn of the fourth beast in Daniel 7:8, 11, 20. But it does not merely speak, it also takes action against the redeemed (13:5–7; 11:7; 12:7; Dan 7:21), for the dragon gives this beast *his power and his throne and great authority* (13:2b). This transfer of authority suggests that secular and non-Christian religious world systems that oppose God or deny Jesus Christ, at any period in human history, were and are instruments of Satan (13:2–3).

The world's inhabitants fall into line and worship this beast (**13:4,** 8). Those who succumb to the lures of the beast and worship it are the ones whose names are not written in *the book of life,* the register of the citizens of heaven (**13:8**; 3:5). But the saints, whose names are in that book, are the ones on whom the beast makes war (**13:7**). Believers who refuse to worship the beast encounter persecution and even martyrdom. We are reminded of the war of Michael and Satan in heaven (12:7) and the attacks on the two witnesses (11:7). Satan and his cohorts will seem to have the upper hand, but the beast's power is limited and will last for only *forty-two months* (**13:5**), during which time God's servants will have to exercise *patience and faithfulness* (**13:10b**). Ultimately God will assert control and the beast will be allowed to persecute the saints no longer. The quotation in **13:10a** echoes Jeremiah 15:1–2, where God's disgust with rebellious individuals is recorded in the words, 'Send them away from my presence! Let them go!'

13:11–18 Act IV, Scene 3: The beast from the land

John now sees *another beast,* this one *coming up out of the earth,* whereas the first beast had come up out of the sea (**13:11**). This distinction may indicate a still closer association with human society,

but not too much should be read into it. In Daniel's vision, the four great beasts that come up out of the sea are explained as four kings who would arise out of the earth (Dan 7:3, 17). The two beasts have a close relationship and they both have a malign influence on human history.

The appearance of this second beast is thoroughly deceptive. It looks *like a lamb* with *two horns,* pretending to be a saviour similar to the Lamb that was slain for our redemption (13:8). But it is a false saviour with a false message of salvation, for its voice is *like a dragon* (13:3) and its lying words are the lying words of the dragon. *It exercised all the authority of the first beast on its behalf,* which implies that it does so under its control (**13:12, 14**). It is thus the agent of the first beast just as the first beast is the agent of the dragon (13:2). Thus both beasts are the instruments of Satan in his warfare against God and his people. Yet because the beast has some of the characteristics of the Lamb, it is easy to understand how people could be deceived and how watchful one has to be to avoid being taken in by what seems plausible and thereby colluding with things or people that are opposed to God.

The primary function of the second beast is to promote the worship of the first beast by *the earth and its inhabitants,* p 1593 that is, on a worldwide scale. In order to do this, he performs signs and wonders like the prophets of God (**13:13**, 15; compare 1 Kgs 18:38), but he is a false prophet (16:13; 19:20; 20:10; Matt 7:15; Acts 13:6).

This worship that the second beast imposes is not a private matter, for those who worship it will receive a mark on their right hand or on their forehead (**13:15–16**; 14:9, 11; 16:2; 19:20; 20:4). This parody of the sealing of the 144,000 in chapter 7 allows them to buy and sell in the marketplace. Those without the mark are denied access to the economy (**13:17**). The reference here is not so much to a literal mark as to the social ostracism of those who refuse to conform.

For John's original readers, this second beast may have symbolized emperor worship, whose 'god' was the continuing line of emperors deified by decree of the Roman senate. This cult had behind it the authority of the emperor. In the name of that authority, it exercised a priestly function (leading men to worship the emperor's image—13:15); a prophetic function (performing great miracles to validate the state religion—13:13); and the power of a grand inquisitor (seeking to brand all people with the mark of the beast without which no one would be able to buy or sell—13:16–17).

The statement that the number of the beast is 666 is probably an example of the ancient practice of *gematria,* whereby numerical values were assigned to words (**13:18b**). In the ancient world, letters were also used for numbers (in our alphabet, A = 1, B = 2, C = 3, and so on), and one could easily convert a person's name into numbers. Since the numerical value of several names could equal 666, the identification of the person John had in mind is not certain.

But there is another way to approach this number, one that is best exemplified in the RSV rendering, *it is a human number,* which moves away from associating the number with a particular person. Instead it focuses on the fact that in Revelation the number 7 (used of angels, churches, seals, trumpets and bowls) implies completeness, whereas the number 6 falls one short of this. The beast seems to be near perfection and almost messianic; it is, after all, a caricature of the Lamb who was slain (13:3, 11, 13). But it is not perfect, and that makes all the difference. It is actually diabolical and utterly opposed to God (13:4). The number 666 represents a threefold falling short of perfection (dragon: 6, beast: 6, false prophet: 6). But it is close to perfection, and has most of the hallmarks of truth, and so can easily deceive. No wonder wisdom is required! (**13:18a**).

14:1–5 Act IV, Scene 4: The Lamb with the 144,000 martyrs

The dismal picture in scene 3 is deliberately followed by the triumphant one of scene 4. Together, these scenes seem to discount the pre-tribulation rapture, for they contrast those who have *[the Lamb's] name and his Father's name written on their foreheads* with those wearing the mark of the beast (**14:1**; 13:16). Humanity is divided into two camps, and no one can belong to both at the same time.

Scene 3 portrays the martyrdom of God's people. Scene 4 reverses that judgment as John sees the Lamb (Christ) standing on Mount Zion, the centre of the messianic kingdom. With him are *144,000* people who, like the heavenly chorus in 5:8–10, sing a *new song* of praise to God, a song that no one else could learn (**14:2–3**). While it is tempting to interpret the 144,000 as symbolic of all redeemed humanity, a closer reading suggests that they are the martyrs, the ones who have been the victims of the beasts in chapter 13. They are described as *firstfruits* (**14:4b**). This is sacrificial language, appropriate for those who have sacrificed their lives for God. These martyrs maintained their witness even under persecution, *no lie was found in their mouths* (**14:5**).

These with the Lamb *did not defile themselves with women, for they kept themselves pure* (**14:4a**). These words need to be interpreted in terms of the regulations for 'holy war', which required sexual abstinence before battle (Deut 23:9–11; 1 Sam 21:4–5; 2 Sam 11:9–11). John uses this requirement for ceremonial purity to symbolize moral and religious purity. The description is figurative, not literal (2 Cor 11:2). It parallels the use of the imagery of fornication as a metaphor for idolatry (see 2:14, 21) and describes the singularity and lack of compromise that abstinence from sexual intercourse involves, reflecting the profound distaste throughout this book for whatever is ambiguous or mixed (3:15–16).

John's vision offers hope to those who stand firm in God. Those who conform to the ways of the beast may achieve temporary prosperity, but ultimately that cannot continue. This certainty should encourage God's people to remain committed to what they believe even at the risk of public disgrace.

14:6–13 Act IV, Scene 5: The messages of the three angels

Scenes 3 and 4 showed us two multitudes: one made up of those who accepted the secular world system and the other of believers. Now in scene 5 we hear three closely related announcements intended to appeal to the peoples of the world to join the ranks of righteousness and to encourage persecuted believers by saying that God is about to receive them into his rest.

The first announcement proclaims the *eternal gospel* and appeals to all peoples to *fear God,* the Creator and the righteous Judge (**14:6–7**). The second proclaims the impending fall of *Babylon the Great,* or the forces of evil (**14:8**). The third is a warning that eternal torment awaits anyone who *worships the beast* (**14:9–11**). All these declarations represent various aspects of God's message, both negative and positive.

Here we have the first mention of the evil city as *Babylon the Great* (14:8; 16:19; 17:5; 18:2). Babylon's offence is to have caused all the nations to *drink the maddening wine of her adulteries* (14:8; Jer 51:7). This phrase seems to mean that Babylon misled people and caused them to forget their true vocation, which is to worship God and faithfully keep his commandments p 1594 (compare 17:2; 18:3). Elsewhere, John speaks of Sodom and Egypt combined as the 'great city'

(11:8). Revelation speaks of only two cities: the 'holy city' (11:2; 21:2), which is of God, and the evil city, which is of Satan. The city of Satan is anywhere and everywhere that people worship something other than the true and living God.

The overall goal of act IV becomes clear at **14:12–13**: it is to commend the saints for their steadfastness even in persecution. If they *die in the Lord,* they will find *rest* with him.

14:14–20 Act IV, Scene 6: Harvest of sinners and redeemed

The conflict between good and evil that is presented in terms of a battle in 9:13–21, 16:12–16 and 19:19–21 is here graphically portrayed as a harvest. Once again, the emphasis lies on the judgment of sinners and the gathering in of the righteous at the end of human history on earth. The imagery comes from chapter 3 in Joel: 'Swing the sickle, for the harvest is ripe. Come, trample the grapes, for the winepress is full and the vats overflow—so great is their wickedness' (Joel 3:13).

The first reaper is described as *like a son of man* and represents the saving aspect of judgment (**14:15–16**). Jesus also used harvest imagery to explain the gathering in of the redeemed (Mark 4:29; Luke 10:2). The other side of the judgment, condemnation, is apparent in the trampling *in the great winepress of God's wrath* (**14:17–19**). The wine flowing from the vat symbolizes the pouring out of the blood of the guilty who have been executed. The magnitude and severity of God's punishment on the wicked is conveyed by the imagery of blood rising as high as the horses' bridles, for a distance of 1600 stadia [180 miles, 300 kilometres] (**14:20**, Isa 63:1–6). The fact that this blood is shed *outside the city* probably refers merely to ancient warfare when a besieged army was slaughtered at the city walls, and the blood flowed outside the city. The city is the same city that was trampled by unbelievers (11:2).

The scale of the judgment shows that this is no human vengeance, but exclusively that of the Son of Man and his angelic reapers.

15:1–4 Act IV, Scene 7: The song of the Lamb

In acts III and IV, John has been describing the events of the last times and their effect on the community of believers, the redeemed people of God. But in this last scene of act IV, John depicts in a few bold strokes the end of human history and the future of *those who had been victorious,* that is, those who have overcome (**15:2b**; see also 2:7, 11, 17, 26; 3:5, 12, 21). Accordingly, we see only the saved, standing by *a sea of glass mixed with fire* (**15:2a**), which is reminiscent of the 'sea of cast metal' and the ten bronze basins of Solomon's temple (1 Kgs 7:23–39). Like those objects, this sea of glass probably stands for the holiness without which no one can approach God. The saved have passed through it, even as Israel passed through the Red Sea. The 'fire' of its judgment has served to purify and not to destroy them. So, like Israel after crossing the Red Sea they pause to sing the song of Moses (Exod 15), with modifications of the original as will make it also the *song of the Lamb* (**15:3**).

The redeemed sing as they play upon *harps given them by God* (**15:2c**). They are enjoying constant fellowship with God. They have 'confidence to enter the Most Holy Place', because they have 'full assurance of faith', which they need 'to draw near to God' for 'he who promised is faithful' (Heb 10:19–23).

So, the curtain falls on act IV, leaving us with the confident assurance that those who have God's seal on their foreheads should not fear persecution that may result in martyrdom. God's seal means that they are God's own possession for ever.

15:5–16:21 Act V: Vision of the Seven Angels—God's Wrath Poured Out

Stage Setting: In this act, the sanctuary has been shifted to the back so that the whole tabernacle with its lampstands, altars and the like is visible. More prominently displayed are seven angels carrying seven bowls of God's wrath.

In act III, we saw believers enduring the great suffering of the 'last times'. In act V, we see how the unbelieving world responds to the same suffering. Like those in act III, the first four scenes of act V contain an elaboration of the cosmic catastrophe presented in 6:12–17. This means that the events of both acts are clearly in the same period of the 'last times.' Both the bowl plagues and the trumpet plagues draw upon the plagues inflicted on Egypt.

Another significant difference between acts III and V is the extent to which the sufferings in act V are said to affect humanity. In act III, humans suffer only in scene 3. This is because John's purpose there was to show how the believing community would successfully weather those horrific times. Here, however, stress is laid on the effect of these plagues on those who have on them the mark of the beast and who worship its image. Ungodly people are not capable of dealing with the daily pressure, and in an attempt to cover up their own inadequacies; they 'curse God'. Act V, therefore, presents a picture of human suffering which rises in a crescendo from 'ugly and painful sores' (16:2), to scorching by the fierce heat of the sun (16:8–9) to 'huge hailstones of about a hundred pounds [forty kilograms] each' (16:21). What a picture of unrelieved torment! This exhibition of God's wrath against sin can be described as the gospel message in reverse.

15:5–16:1 Before the tabernacle

In addition to contrasting the reaction of believers and unbelievers to suffering, acts III and V present the angels in contrasting roles. Act III shows the angels as messengers of p 1595 God's saving power, while act V show them as messengers of wrath. There is also a contrast with respect to the *tabernacle of the Testimony* (**15:5**). In acts III and IV, we saw the people of God at prayer and the tabernacle fully displayed. Here in act V, the tabernacle is pushed into the background and no one is able to enter it *until the seven plagues of the seven angels were completed* (**15:8**). This recalls Exodus 40:34–35 where 'Moses could not enter the Tent of Meeting, because … the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle', that is, for the moment the majesty of God's presence was too overpowering for any human to look upon. Here in Revelation it means that nothing can withstand God's wrath against a sinful world. The approach to him is closed and there is no recourse for disobedient humanity during the last judgment. Little wonder that this act closes with the words, 'the plague was so terrible' (16:21).

16:2 Act V, Scene 1: The plague on the earth

The pouring out of the first bowl results in painful sores (compare Exod 9:10, 11; Luke 16:20, 21). This plague specifically affects those *who had the mark of the beast and who worshipped its image* (13:15, 16; 7:3).

16:3 Act V, Scene 2: The plague on the sea

Then the second angel empties his bowl into the sea, and the sea turns bloody like a corpse (**16:3**; Exod 7:19–21). Whereas in the aftermath of the second trumpet, a third of the creatures in the sea were destroyed (8:8–9), here every living thing in the sea dies.

16:4–7 Act V, Scene 3: The plague on rivers and springs

The third angel pours out his bowl into the rivers and springs of water and they turn into blood (Exod 7:17–18). In 8:10–11, these same waters were made 'bitter'; the *angel in charge of the waters* responds by acknowledging God's righteous judgment (**16:5–6**), hailing him as *the Holy One* (as in 15:4) and judge (6:10; 11:17–18; 18:8, 20; 19:11; Ps 119:137). In response, a voice from the altar of sacrifice says, *Yes, Lord God Almighty, true and just are your judgments* (**16:7**).

16:8–9 Act V, Scene 4: The plague on the sun

The fourth angel empties his bowl onto the sun releasing scorching heat on the earth (**16:8**). When people begin burning, they start cursing *the name of God* (**16:9**, 11, 21; 13:6). They recognize that he has ultimate *control over these plagues* but as in 9:20 they give no sign of repentance and do not give God glory (11:13; 14:7).

16:10–11 Act V, Scene 5: The plague on the beast's throne

The first four plagues affected all parts of the cosmos: land, waters, sea and sun. Next, the very citadel of the beast is attacked. The fifth angel pours out his bowl of judgment on the throne of the beast (2:13), and as a result, *his kingdom was plunged into darkness* (**16:10**; compare 8:12; 9:2; Exod 10:22; Matt 24:29; 27:45; Acts 2:20). Despite the great suffering, the people are so hardened against God that nothing is able to bring them to repentance (**16:11**).

16:12–16 Act V, Scene 6: The plague on the Euphrates River

The sixth angel pours forth his bowl upon the Euphrates River. As a result, its waters dry up in preparation for a highway over which the *kings from the East* will travel (**16:12**; 9:13–19). The drying up of the Euphrates River reminds us of the drying up of the Red Sea. The frogs in the scene are reminiscent of the second Egyptian plague (**16:13**; Exod 7:25–8:15), but these are no ordinary frogs. They are demonic spirits who gather together the kings of the earth for a great spiritual battle (**16:14**), one that will be between ideologies and not one of swords and guns.

This is the first time John explicitly mentions the battle of Armageddon, though he has hinted before at its coming. Scenes 6 of this act and of act III describe armies from across the Euphrates who invade the west (9:13–21; 14:14–20; see also 19:19–21). The place where the armies will assemble for battle is called *Armageddon* (**16:16**). The name probably derives from the Hebrew

words, *Har Megiddo,* meaning 'the mountain of Megiddo'. Megiddo was an important city guarding the pass through the Jezreel Valley in Israel. Several important battles had been fought there in the past (Judg 5:19). It was the site of the death of Ahaziah (2 Kgs 9:27) and of the defeat of the righteous reforming king Josiah (2 Kgs 23:29). It seems likely that John is not predicting a literal battle at this place, but is using it as a symbol of the final attempt by the forces of evil to defeat God's supremacy. John does not give any description of the confrontation. He will do that in 19:11–21.

Here he gives an admonition from Christ, *Behold, I come like a thief! Blessed is he who stays awake and keeps his clothes with him, so that he may not go naked and be shamefully exposed* (**16:15**). This is a warning against being spiritually unprepared for the coming of Christ, which will occur unexpectedly (Matt 25:1–13). There is no interlude between bowls six and seven, as there was with the seals and trumpets.

Because of the similarities between the scenes of the seals, trumpets and bowls (6:1–16:21), it is possible to treat them as describing one series of suffering. They represent the frequent and intense suffering experienced in different parts of the world throughout human history rather than a chronological series of tribulations just before the second coming of Christ. The emptying of the seventh bowl occuring brings down the curtain on the eschatological drama.

16:17–21 Act V, Scene 7: The plague on the air

The seventh angel empties his bowl into the air and in response, a loud voice comes out of the temple, from the p 1596 throne, shouting, *It is done!* (**16:17**). This is God's confirmation of the work of the Lamb and echoes the Lamb's own words on the cross (John 19:30). The *earthquake* too is reminiscent of the one after the agony of the Lamb (**16:18**; Matt 27:51). In Revelation earthquakes accompany significant moments: the opening of the sixth seal, which prompted a response of fear on the part of humanity (6:12–16); the ascent of the prayers of the saints to God (8:4); the resurrection of the two witnesses, which prompted fear in the inhabitants of the city (11:13); and following the seventh trumpet blast and the second woe, when God's reign is seen to be effective (11:19).

Here the implication is that the end has fully come; the evil city, *Babylon the Great,* has finally fallen (**16:19**). This scene of terror is in sharp contrast to its counterpart of the 'survivors' giving glory to God in act III (**16:21**; 11:13).

17:1–20:3 Act VI: Vision of the Doom of Evil

Stage Setting: There is no difference from the arrange of the stage in act V, except that the sanctuary is pushed farther to the back of the stage and the Earth's corners become visible. But one of the seven angels still plays a role.

As the curtain fell on act V, we looked forward with trepidation to the filling in of details in the drama of judgment. The motif of judgment runs throughout this Act. But the throne of God, with the worshipping creatures and elders, is still to be seen in the distance. The judgment passed on the 'great harlot' is God's doing, and his all-seeing eye does not fail to observe that judgment carried out.

One of the seven angels who has been pouring out the wrath of God stands alone in the centre of the stage. This angel offers to show John the judgment of Babylon, a theme that will occupy the whole of chapters 17 and 18. These two chapters form an extended appendix, as it were, to the seventh bowl where the judgment on Babylon was first mentioned (16:19). They also expand upon the earlier references to this city (11:8; 14:8) and look forward to the eternal Holy City (21:1–22:5).

It is a characteristic of John's literary technique that he occasionally brings a principal character upon the stage abruptly, without any previous introduction or description. This was true of the beast arising from the Abyss (11:7) and it is true of the woman here. And while the detailed interpretation of this type of vision is common in apocalyptic literature, it is not found in the rest of Revelation. This vision is followed by a sequence of heavenly celebration and earthly laments over Babylon's fate as John shows the city's true character and identity and the reactions both on earth and in heaven to its demise.

17:1–6a Act VI, Scene 1: The woman on the scarlet beast

John is approached by one of the angels who had held the seven bowls of plagues. He is taken into the *desert* by the Spirit (**17:3a**; compare 1:10; 4:2; 21:10; Ezek 8:3), where he comes face to face with Babylon, just as Jesus had come face to face with Satan (Matt 4:1–11). This is the second time *a desert* is stretched before us on the stage (12:6). It seems clear that the events of act VI are to be viewed as depicting the same conflict between good and evil as do the events of act IV. There, God has prepared a place of safety for his people in the desert. As already noted, in Scripture a *desert* can also be a place of temptation or testing (Mark 1:12–13), of rebellion (Exod 17:1–7; Heb 3:8), or of punishment (Num 14:20–23; Heb 3:17).

John is summoned to the desert to witness the judgment of the *great prostitute* (**17:1**). The angel describes this prostitute as one who *sits on many waters,* a phrase that recalls Jeremiah's description of Babylon as 'you who live by mighty waters' (Jer 51:13). The woman John sees here is clearly not the same as the godly woman mentioned in chapter 12. This woman is seated on a scarlet beast that is *covered with blasphemous names* (**17:3b**; Dan 7:24–25). The beast has *seven heads* and *ten horns,* like the beast that arose from the sea (13:1). Unlike the redeemed, who are clothed in white (4:4; 7:9, 13; 19:14), she is *dressed in purple and scarlet* (**17:4a**). She is adorned with gold, precious stones and pearls and holds a golden cup *filled with abominable things and the filth of her impurities* in her hand (**17:4b**). Readers would recall the 'maddening wine' of Babylon (14:8) and now they are seeing its embodiment in the *great prostitute,* Babylon, with whom *the kings of the earth committed adultery* (**17:2a**). She has made all the earth drunk (**17:2b**; 18:3; Jer 51:7) and is herself drunk with *the blood of the saints, the blood of those who bore testimony to Jesus* (**17:6a**).

The imagery here is derived from Ezekiel's dramatic condemnation of Tyre (Ezek 28:1–19), which he presented as a proud city that had amassed great wealth through trade with other nations (Ezek 28:5). But that prosperity would ultimately end in devastation (Ezek 28:18–19). The woman's name is *mystery, Babylon the great, the mother of prostitutes and of the abominations of the earth* (**17:5**).

Solving the 'mystery' of what Babylon represents is important for interpreting the manifestation of evil not only in this chapter but in the whole of Revelation. For the majority of commentators, 'Babylon' stands for the city of Rome, and the beast on which she sits is the Roman Empire with its subject provinces and peoples. But this identification may be inadequate. Babylon cannot be any one historical city. John's description does not neatly fit any particular city; whether the real

Babylon, Sodom, Tyre, Nineveh or Rome. Theologically, Babylon is found wherever there is satanic deception. It is defined more by dominant idolatries than by geographic boundaries. Babylon is better understood as the embodiment of all entrenched worldly resistance to God. It is a supernatural mystery that can never be wholly reducible to any individual earthly institution or city. The historical Rome was, therefore, only one of the manifestations p 1597 of the total system of humankind that excludes God from what it does. As act VI progresses, the lesson that is relentlessly driven home is that evil is always self-destructive and that in the end only God can overcome it.

17:6b–18 Act VI, Scene 2: The beast at war with the woman

The vision of the great prostitute is followed by the interpretation of that vision by an angel who explains the mystery of Babylon and the beast that carries her. Though seldom used in Revelation, such angelic interpretation is a feature of other works of apocalyptic literature (Dan 7–12). The nature of the beast is explained in 17:7–8, then that of its seven heads (17:9–11) and ten horns (17:12–14). The meaning of the waters is explained in 17:15 and of the woman in 17:18.

John is told that the beast *once was, now is not, and will come up out of the Abyss* (**17:8,** 11). These words seem to echo the earlier reference to the fatally wounded beast who was healed (13:3, 12, 14). The tenses: *was … is not … will come* indicate that the beast has a three-stage history that can only be understood by *a mind with wisdom* (**17:9**). Satan once had power before his fall, then he was rendered impotent by the death of the Lord Jesus Christ on the cross, and yet he is allowed a *little while* (**17:10b**) to oppose God and his people before finally being sentenced to *destruction* at the second coming of Christ (**17:11**; Matt 7:13; John 17:12; Rom 9:22; 2 Thess 2:3). Thus it seems that this beast is the satanic incarnation of idolatrous power first mentioned in 11:7 and described in 13:1–3, and whose destruction is seen in 19:19–20.

This interpretation links the call for *a mind with wisdom* to the identification of the beast, and not to the issue of the *seven hills* on which Rome was built (17:9; note that the woman also sits on 'many waters'—17:1, 15—and on the beast—17:3). It was common knowledge that Rome was built on seven hills and no particular wisdom would have been required to see that link. It is also difficult to see how this geographic feature of Rome has any real symbolic significance related to the diabolic nature of the beast or the woman. Nor is the actual historical city described as the enemy of the Christian community anywhere else in the NT. Some scholars thus argue that the woman does not represent the city of Rome, but the Roman Empire, but this view is contradicted by the clear statement in 17:18 that the woman represents a city, and by the statement that it is the beast that has seven heads.

The seven heads of the beast are said to represent both seven hills and *seven kings* (**17:10a**). Those who see the city as Rome argue that the *seven kings* represent seven successive Roman emperors. But how are these to be counted? If five Roman emperors *have fallen,* the *one* who *is* should be Galba (Nero's successor), and the one who *has not yet come* should be Otho. But if Galba and his successors (Otho and Vitellius) who had very short reigns are included (and they should since they appear on the list of legitimate Roman emperors), then the argument for only seven emperors falls apart because the Roman Empire had many more emperors. So some scholars have interpreted the seven kings as a succession of world kingdoms. The first five are said to be Egypt, Assyria, Babylon, Persia and Greece. Rome is understood as a future world kingdom that will oppress the people of God. The problem with this view is that it arbitrarily omits many other kingdoms that have persecuted God's people throughout history, and does not explain how the kings (or kingdoms) it

identifies can be seen to have survived the destruction of the prostitute and be pictured as mourning her in 18:9. Nor does the political history of Rome include a Roman emperor turning against the city or empire and destroying her, as implied in 17:16–17.

Any convincing interpretation of the seven kings must do justice to three considerations: First, since the heads belong to the beast, the interpretation must relate their significance to this beast, not to Babylon. Second, since kingship in Revelation often involves conflict between the Lamb and the beast (**17:14**; 19:19), the kind of sovereignty expressed in 17:10 must be the opposite of that exercised by Christ and his followers. And third, since the kings are closely related to the seven hills and to the great prostitute, the nature of the relationship between them must be clarified.

All these considerations are satisfied by an interpretation which recognizes that throughout Revelation, seven is a symbolic number that indicates perfection or fullness. The *seven heads* therefore represent the totality of evil and blasphemy. They represent a quality, not a quantity. The falling of five heads thus represents a significant victory over the beast—and thus God's judgment on the powers of evil throughout human history (14:8; 18:2; Jer 50:23; 51:8–9, 49).

The ten horns (Dan 7:7, 24) are often interpreted as either native rulers of Roman provinces serving under Roman emperors, or native rulers of satellite states, or governors of Palestine. But the number 10—like most of John's numbers—should be understood symbolically. Ten symbolizes that something is repeated a number of times or an indefinite number (2:10; Neh 4:12; Dan 1:12). Thus the number should not be understood as referring specifically to ten kings or kingdoms, but as indicating the many political sovereignties that enhance the power of the beast throughout human history. These rulers and the beast with which they are allied are the principalities and powers, 'the rulers of the darkness of this world' (Eph 6:12 KJV). To be sure, they use earthly instruments, but their reality is far greater than any specific historical equivalents. These *kings* embody the fullness of Satan's attack against the Lamb and believers worldwide. They are the 'kings from the East' (16:12–14) and the 'kings of the earth' (19:19–21).

p 1598 The ten kings are said to receive authority for *one hour* (**17:12**). This corresponds to the 'little while' for which the seventh king will reign (17:10). They will reign along with the beast, which is described as an *eighth king* who *belongs to the seven* (17:11). This promise that their reign will be short brings comfort to the persecuted saints.

The influence of the satanic system of Babylon is universal (17:1–2), and it affects all humanity, from the humblest to the proud political leaders of the world, but it is not invincible. The prostitute will be brought *to ruin,* left *naked and* burned *with fire* (**17:16**) by her former lovers, an image that reminds us of the OT prophets' descriptions of the divine judgment falling on Jerusalem, Samaria and Tyre (Ezek 16:39–40; 23:25–27; 28:17–19). The description of the punishment of a convicted prostitute is combined with the picture of judgment against rebellious cities (18:8; Lev 21:9).

The ravaging of the prostitute by the beast and its horns is John's most vivid symbol for the self-destroying power of evil. The attack on the prostitute indicates the final judgment on the kingdom of Satan, for *God has put it into their hearts to accomplish his purpose* (**17:17**). God can use the forces of evil as instruments of his judgment (Jer 25:9–14). Nothing will distract them from their united effort to destroy the prostitute till God's purpose is fulfilled (10:7; 11:18).

The fact that this *woman* is said to be identical to *the great city* shows that this 'city' is not just a historical one (**17:18**). Her other names are 'the great prostitute' (17:1), 'Babylon the Great' (17:5), 'mother of prostitutes' (17:5), 'Sodom' (11:8) and 'Egypt' (11:8). She stands for those in every place

and time who seek to oppose and destroy any people of God. Her kingdom *rules over the kings of the earth,* that is, through political and ungodly systems that ignore and exclude God from their belief and behaviour.

18:1–19:10 Act VI, Scene 3: Fallen is Babylon the Great

Scene 3 marks the climax and fulfilment of John's prophecy about the fall of Babylon (17:1). It opens with an announcement of its general theme. This is followed by an appeal to God's people to leave Babylon, a wailing lament, an acted parable and sermon delivered by a mighty angel, and choruses of Hallelujah. This scene contains some of the most beautiful language in the whole book. It draws on OT accounts of the destruction of ancient cities like Babylon (Isa 13:19–22; 47:7–15; Jer 50–51) and Tyre (Ezek 26–28) to create a great funeral dirge (compare 2 Sam 1:17–27; Isa 14:4–21).

So magnificent is the coming event that a dazzling angel of glory bears the divine news (**18:1**). In words very similar to those of the OT prophets the angel announces that *Babylon the Great* has fallen (**18:2**; Isa 21:9). The city is judged because of her *adulteries* and *excessive luxuries* (**18:3**; **7,** 9), suggesting that she is guilty of both idolatry and pride (Ezek 28:4–5, 16–18). John's vision also allows readers some glimpse of how Babylon had gained her wealth at the expense of others (**18:5–6, 13**). A godless system may have great beauty, sophistication and splendour, and its arts, social life and technology may flourish, but these attributes should not be enjoyed at the expense of human life and human rights. All human beings are made in the image of God.

Come out of her, my people (**18:4**) is also Jeremiah's call concerning Babylon (Jer 50:8; 51:6–9; see also Isa 48:20; 52:11; 2 Cor 6:17). Even in its OT setting, this was no mere warning to leave the city of Babylon. John, like the OT prophets, is exhorting God's people to shun the charms and snares of the prostitute city. Babylon exists wherever there is idolatry, prostitution, self-glorification, self-sufficiency, pride and complacency, reliance on luxury and wealth, and violence against life (18:4–8, 24). Believers are to separate themselves from all the forms of Babylon. While they still have to live and work in the world, they also need to claim a distinctive identity and to develop habits of resistance that will enable witness to take place.

Three groups of people lament the city's fall: the *kings of the earth* (**18:9–10**), the *merchants of the earth* who traded with her (**18:11–17a**), and the *sea captains* who became rich from the cargoes they took to the city (**18:17b–20**; see Ezek 27:27–33). With bitter irony, these dirges pronounce 'Woe!' on God's enemies. They are chanted by those who have profited most from the secular systems symbolized by the great prostitute. They are now helpless to save her and can only throw dust on their heads and stand afar off, *weeping and mourning* (18:9–10, 15, 17–19)—traditional symbols of repentance. The suddenness of God's judgment is stressed in the phrase *in one hour* (18:17).

The final fate of Babylon is presented with an image that draws on Jesus' judgment on those who try to deceive his followers. 'If anyone causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin, it would be better for him to be thrown into the sea with a large millstone tied around his neck' (Mark 9:42). John sees a mighty angel pick up a *boulder the size of a large millstone* (**18:21**). Such a millstone would be around five feet (one and a half metres) in diameter, one foot (thirty centimetres) thick, and would weigh thousands of pounds. With one quick gesture, the angel flings it into the sea. Suddenly the city is gone for ever (Jer 51:64; Ezek 26:21).

This acted parable symbolizes the whole judgment on Babylon. Revelation uses similar prophetic symbolism in the measuring of the sanctuary in 11:1–2, and the sealing of the redeemed in 7:2–8. It is also common in prophetic writings: for example, Jeremiah's linen girdle (Jer 13:1–11), Hosea's adulterous wife (Hos 1–3), and Ezekiel's mimic siege of Jerusalem (Ezek 4:1–3).

p 1599 This judgment is a death blow to the life of the city (18:21–23a). The reason for such severe judgment is cited again in **18:23–24**: Babylon has led *all the nations … astray* and she has martyred both the OT *prophets* and some NT *saints* because of their loyalty to the true God (see 17:6; 19:2). Elsewhere in Revelation, the death of martyrs is attributed to the inhabitants of the earth (6:9–10), the beast from the Abyss (11:7; 13:7) and the beast from the earth (13:15). All these have been agents or instruments of Satan.

It is fitting that Babylon's sinfulness and persecution of God's people are reiterated here, for these sins summarize the sins repeated throughout the book of Revelation. John is witnessing God's final judgment on every human institution that opposes God's righteous rule and sovereignty.

The great chorus of the heavenly choir in 19:1–8 opens with a resounding *Hallelujah.* This word, which means 'Praise the Lord!' occurs only in this chapter in the whole NT (19:1, 3, 4, 6). In the OT, it is used mainly in the psalms, especially in Psalms 113–118, which were associated with the Passover. These psalms were used to celebrate the exodus and the destruction of the wicked, exactly as this passage in Revelation does. They would have been sung by Jesus and his disciples after the Passover celebration, before going out to the Mount of Olives the night before his death (Matt 26:30).

The theme of the praise is in the opening words: *salvation and glory and power belong to our God.* First, the choir praise God for the condemnation of the prostitute (**19:1–2**), and then they shout in celebration of the city's eternal destruction (**19:3**). The twenty-four elders and the four living creatures respond with their own praise (**19:4**). Finally, a voice from the throne calls on all the servants of God to praise him (**19:5**).

In 19:6–10, we hear the praises of God's people because *our Lord God Almighty reigns* (Ps 118:24) and *the wedding of the Lamb has come.* The multitude in 19:1 cannot be angelic since it is composed of the redeemed. All the redeemed appear on the cosmic stage, dressed in *fine, bright and clean* linen, which is the court dress demanded in the throne room of the King of kings.

John uses the OT image of Israel as a bride (Ezek 16; Hos 2:19–20), which the NT applies to God's people (2 Cor 11:2; Eph 5:25–26). *Those who are invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb* (**19:9a;** Luke 13:29) are the believers of all ages. To assure John and his readers of the certainty of the end of the great prostitute and the announcement of the wedding supper of the Lamb, the angel adds, *These are the true words of God* (**19:9b**; compare 1:2; 21:5; 22:6).

The closing episode of scene 3 is a bit like that in the interlude at the end of act III (10:1–11). In both scenes, John is drawn into the spotlight and we overhear a conversation between him and an angel. John mistakenly assumes that the angel is a divine being, possibly the Lord Jesus Christ, and prostrates himself to *worship* the angel, but is quickly prohibited from doing so (**19:10**). In the OT, men prostrate themselves before angels (Num 22:31; 1 Chr 21:16), but they do this in homage, not in worship. There is no place in Christianity for the worship of anyone except God.

Some early Christians were tempted to worship angels (Col 2:18), but this passage rebukes the practice. We need to recognize how easy it is to fall into idolatry. Whenever a Christian gives anyone

or anything other than God control of his or her life, he or she has broken the first commandment (Exod 20:1–3).

The angel links himself with John by calling himself *a fellow-servant with you.* Angels and human beings are very different, but they have something important in common. Both are servants of the Lord.

19:11–16 Act VI, Scene 4: The rider on a white horse

The judgment of the wicked city is followed by a vision of the return of Christ and the establishment of the eternal city of God in 19:11–22:5. Christ's coming is portrayed through a series of symbolic pictures, which highlight aspects of the event too great to comprehend in advance.

When heaven is opened the first thing John sees is *Faithful and True* riding a *white horse* (**19:11**). Unlike the similar rider in 6:1–2, this rider comes out of heaven, which stands open. In other words, he emerges from the sanctuary at the back of the stage. The statement that *no one knows* the full name of the rider means that no one can fathom the depth of his person (**19:12**). The rider and those who follow him are dressed for battle and are assembling for the battle of Armageddon (16:12–16; 19:13–14). In 14:1–5 this same group was seen as the Lamb and the 144,000 redeemed people assembled on Mount Zion.

The rider is also called *the Word of God* (**19:13**) and *out of his mouth comes a sharp sword,* which is his answer to the foul lies of the dragon (**19:15**; 1:16). He will win the battle of Armageddon, for he is *Faithful and True,* the one who is destined to carry through the purpose of God to its final conclusion. Therefore, the appropriate title which will eventually be his is *king of kings and lord of lords.*

19:17–18 Act VI, Scene 5: The angel standing in the sun

It seems there is to be another feast. First there was the 'wedding supper' … for Christ's own people. Now there is the *great supper* of his wrath on the field of Armageddon to which *the birds flying in mid-air* are summoned (**19:17**; Ezek 39:4, 17–20). In his mercy, God has repeatedly given people opportunities to repent of their idolatries, immorality, sorcery and murders and to return to him. Again and again throughout John's drama of human history, they have refused to respond positively to God's mercy and grace (Jer 4:1–2). Although God desires everyone to be saved, he will p 1600 not force anyone to repent and to turn to him. But the time for his judgment has come.

19:19–21 Act VI, Scene 6: The battle of Armageddon

We are given surprisingly few details about the battle of Armageddon. Ever since it was first mentioned in 16:12–16, we have been anticipating a description of the terrain over which the battle would be fought, the tactics and the nature of the battle itself. However, the lack of detail ought not to surprise us, for this battle is the same one that John has been describing all along. The 'great tribulation' (7:14) seems to be the same as the battle of Armageddon (16:16).

The battle of Armageddon is a war of ideologies, with righteousness opposing evil; 'Faithful and True', 'the Word of God' riding on the 'white horse' (19:11–15) opposing 'the beast' and its 'false

prophet' (16:13). The destined result of this long warfare is that *the beast* and its *false prophet* will be cast into *the fiery lake of burning sulphur* (**19:20**), eternally banished from the presence of God.

20:1–3 Act VI, Scene 7: Satan, thrown into the abyss

We have just witnessed the final end of the beast and its false prophet. Now we will witness the judgment of God on the dragon, Satan himself, who has all along been instigating rebellion against the rule of God. It is important to resist the temptation to see 20:1–10 as sequentially following the events described in 19:1–21. The author is not giving the order in which future events will take place.

This scene, like other visions in this section of the drama begins with its own introductory formula: *And I saw* (**20:1a**). An angel with *the key to the Abyss* and *a great chain* (**20:1b**) comes down from heaven and seizes and binds Satan. The evil one is described here by all four titles, *the dragon,* the *ancient serpent, the devil* and *Satan,* so that readers know exactly who the angel is dealing with (**20:2a**).

The Greek word translated *bound* can be used literally (Mark 11:2) and figuratively (Luke 13:11, 16). When used figuratively, it can refer to freeing someone from the power exercised over him or her by a sorcerer, or spirit. To free someone from this power is 'to loose' them. By his death and resurrection Jesus Christ broke the grip of the devil on men and nations and set them free from spiritual bondage (Heb 2:14). Now the gates of hell will not prevail against Christ's church (Matt 16:18).

The *key to the Abyss* and *the great chain* are clearly symbolic for there can be no material key to the immaterial bottomless abyss. Nor can Satan, a spiritual being, be shackled with a physical chain. We can thus also take the *thousand years* for which Satan is to be bound as symbolic (**20:2b**). As already noted, one thousand symbolizes an immense total. It is the cube of ten, a number of completeness. If we take this approach, John is simply saying that Satan is bound for the complete time that God has determined since his fall from heaven.

While the central thesis of many popular eschatological positions is that in the future there will be a kingdom lasting *a thousand years*, this passage does not mention any such kingdom. In the gospels, Jesus taught that the kingdom of God was inaugurated with his coming and was now present though not yet fulfilled (Matt 12:28). The presence of Christ is in one sense the kingdom of God invading and transforming human history. Satan is a strong angelic being whose house is 'this present evil age' (Gal 1:4). The victory over Satan by Jesus Christ is the same whether it is described as tying up the strong man (Matt 12:29) or stripping him of his armour (Luke 11:21–22).

In this scene, John takes up a rich motif within the Semitic world. For example, in Iranian apocalyptic literature there is an evil serpent, *Azi-Dahaka,* who is chained up at the End. In the apocalyptic sections of the OT, it is also said that the powers of evil 'will be herded together like prisoners bound in a dungeon; they will be shut up in prison and be punished after many days' (Isa 24:21–22). Thus here too the binding of these powers is presented as a holding station, as it were, before the final judgment (2 Pet 2:4; Jude 6).

The three verbs in **20:3**—*threw … locked and sealed*—have the same ring of finality as our 'signed, sealed, and delivered'. These verbs communicate that Satan is under God's complete control. He is locked up not as a punishment, but in order that he may not deceive 'the nations', a

word that can mean nations, people (as compared to kings), foreigners, Gentiles, and Gentile Christians (for example, Gal 2:12, 14; Eph 3:1). Satan's activity of deception is also brought under control and restrained.

Theologically, binding Satan does not mean eliminating all his activities in this life, and he remains a dangerous foe who still rages against God's people since his fall from heaven. So the binding of Satan speaks of God's sovereign control over him. Satan has never had free rein to do whatever he wants (Job 2:6). It is the light of the gospel that exposes the darkness of satanic deception, and the preaching of Christ crucified which sets men and women free from the control and power of Satan (Matt 28:19, 20). And Satan is under the sovereign authority and control of Christ until God's purposes for humanity are finished. The power of evil is temporary, and it only operates by divine consent.

20:4–22:5 Act VII: Vision of Eternal Life

Stage Setting: On the stage in heaven are the thrones of Christ and the martyred saints. The following scenes depict the eternal fate of Satan, the beast and the false prophet, all the unbelievers, and 'death and Hades' as well as the eternal state of the kingdom of God for his people. p 1601

20:4–10 Act VII, Scene 1: The martyred saints

Although the theme of the binding of Satan (20:1–3) and the thousand year reign (20:4–6) are separate themes in apocalyptic literature, the two events are combined here. This vision seems to draw on Daniel 7:2–14, 23–27, another apocalyptic section of the Bible, so that the restraining of the dragon in Revelation 20:1–3 coincides with the moment when dominion is given to the 'one like a son of man' in Daniel 7:9–14.

This section of Revelation has generated endless debates, and sometimes bitter disputes within the Christian community. Therefore, it is very important to approach it with humility and tolerance, as none of us can claim a definitive and absolutely correct interpretation of this passage. If Peter could openly admit that some of Paul's writings were hard for him to understand (2 Pet 3:15–16), who are we to say we know it all? Moreover, even John, like Daniel, did not always understand what he was actually asked to record (Rev 7:14; 17:6b–7).

The point on which we can all agree is that Jesus Christ promised his followers that he would return. The various views disagree on secondary issues related to the nature and timing of that second coming. Instead of attacking those who hold different views, Christians should try to listen to and learn from each other.

The three main interpretations of this passage can be categorized as premillennial, postmillennial and amillennial. The word 'millennium', comes from the Latin word for one thousand.

- *Premillennialists* ('pre-' means 'before') hold that at Christ's return the Christian dead will be raised and believers still living on earth will be caught up to meet him in the air (1 Thess 4:17). They believe that Christ's second coming will take place before his thousand-year reign on earth and that believers will then reign on earth with Christ for a literal thousand years. Then Satan will be released for a short time. This short period of seven years will be followed by the raising of the rest of the dead. In this way there is an explanation of two resurrections that seem to be

mentioned in 20:5. Premillennialists would deny that Satan is bound in this present age since he is so obviously active. They are quick to remind Christians that elsewhere John stresses the devil's present activity (12:12). For premillennialists the symbols and numbers in Revelation are to be interpreted according to their natural meaning unless the context clearly indicates otherwise. But if that were true, then, when John said that Satan would be bound with a chain, did he mean a real chain (though the devil is spirit)? If not, why then should one insist on a literal thousand years? In answer to such questions, premillennialists would insist that if these symbols are not taken in their literal sense, they can be twisted to mean almost anything, and that while the chains may not be literal, the years could be. In other words, while it would not be natural to say that the devil who is spirit would be tied with a literal chain, there is nothing unnatural in saying one thousand literal years.

- *Postmillennialists* ('post-' means 'after') see the return of Christ as taking place after the millennium. Some of them interpret the millennium as the current triumph of the gospel in this age; others consider it a literal one thousand years of triumph of the gospel before Christ returns at the end of the time. Postmillennialists and premillennialists agree that the events of Revelation 19 occur before those of chapter 20.

- Amillennialists ('a-' means 'no') hold that there is no literal millennium, and insist that the thousand-year period is symbolic of the whole time between the life of Jesus on earth and his second coming. They interpret the *first resurrection* (**20:5**) as a reference to the new birth or spiritual regeneration, understood as a resurrection from the spiritual death of sin (Eph 2:1–2). The main weakness of this view is that in context, 'the first resurrection' cannot possibly refer to Christian conversion.

These very different positions show how difficult, and sometimes impossible, it is to impose particular eschatological interpretations on a book that is primarily an apocalyptic book rather than an eschatological exposé.

However, by looking more closely at the context of the book, one finds another way to understand the meaning of 'first resurrection.' John *saw thrones* (**20:4a**; Dan 7:9), which those who expect a literal millennium usually place on earth. But all of John's forty-seven references to 'a throne' or 'thrones' in Revelation locate the throne in heaven, except for Satan's throne (2:13) and that of the beast (13:2; 16:10). John does not say how many thrones there are or who sits on them, but he does immediately go on to speak of those slain for Jesus' sake as reigning for a thousand years. From this one can presume that they are the ones who sit on the thrones with *authority to judge.*

It is interesting to see that John refers to *the souls* of these martyrs, and not to their bodies (**20:4b**; contrast 1 Cor 15:51–57; 1 Thess 4:14–17). The same expression is used with reference to the slain witnesses under the altar (6:9). The term *souls* describes those who have lost their bodily life but are nevertheless still alive and are now in the presence of God in heaven. They will resume their bodily life at the first resurrection.

It is said that the souls of these martyrs *came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years* (**20:4c**). The exact translation of these words reflects different eschatological views. The translation 'they came to life and reigned with Christ' implies resurrection, but the Greek can also be translated 'they lived in the presence of Christ', which does not have to imply bodily resurrection. John specifically p 1602 mentions the presence of *souls* in heaven during 'the one thousand years'.

Of the twenty-two NT occurrences of the Greek verb translated 'to reign', seven are in Revelation. Outside the gospels, the verb refers either to the presence of royalty or to being in presence of royalty rather than to any actual exercise of authority over subjects. For example, in 5:10 and 22:5, 'reign' indicates that at the second coming of Christ, all believers will be in the presence of God eternally in the new Jerusalem. In 11:15 and 19:6 it refers to the presence of the all-powerful God. And here in 20:4, 6, it means that saints who die before the second coming of Christ will have access to his royal presence in heaven with Christ (2 Cor 5:6, 8; 1 Thess 4:13–18). These souls are differentiated from *the rest of dead* who do not live in the presence of the Lord but who are raised at 'the first resurrection' at the end of the thousand years (20:5). John thus speaks of only one resurrection.

The premillennial position assumes a second resurrection, which the text does not mention at all, and also faces the problem that the saints are in heaven, and not on earth, during the one thousand years. When the first resurrection does take place at the end of that time, it will be an experience of all people, including believers of all ages (**20:6**, 11–15). It thus appears that those who reign with Christ for a thousand years are those believers who die before his second coming. This echoes similar teaching elsewhere in the Bible: 'We … would prefer to be away from the body and at home with the Lord' (2 Cor 5:8). For saints, physical death means gaining access to the presence of Christ in heaven.

The 'first resurrection' in 20:5 is contrasted with the 'second death' in 20:6. It seems that here 'first' is not primarily meant to indicate a chronological order but rather a contrast between the first world and the new world order that will last forever. Believers who have lived in the fallen creation will be raised to a second life in God's new world. There will be no death for them in that world. Death in that second world is the final fiery *lake of burning sulphur*, from which there is no resurrection (20:10).

Upon his release, Satan goes out to the ends of the earth to deceive the nations and gather them for battle (**20:7–8**). The fact that he has been released by God shows that the end time is under God's control, not Satan's. Satan is busy, but he is restrained from doing his worst. He cannot spiritually destroy God's people. He cannot even obliterate the souls of martyred saints for they are living in the presence of Christ (20:4).

Where do the nations come from when they have all been destroyed already (19:18, 21)? The answer probably is that John is again not writing chronologically, but is speaking of the same nations associated with the beast and the false prophet throughout human history. *Gog and Magog* were Israel's great enemies to the north (Ezek 38–39), while in Revelation 20:7, they represent all the nations. In apocalyptic writings, Gog and Magog often symbolize the forces of evil. For John the combination of these two is another way of referring to the hosts of the wicked and depicting the intensity of the attack of evil on the things of God.

God's final judgment of Satan and the nations is certain: *Fire came down from heaven and devoured them* (**20:9**). And the devil, who has deceived them, is thrown into *the lake of burning sulphur, where the beast and the false prophet had been thrown* (**20:10**; 19:20).

20:11–15 Act VII, Scene 2: The last judgment

John sees a *great white throne* (**20:11a**). He does not tell us whether God the Father or Christ is sitting on the throne, but it is probably the Father. Other references tell us that the Father is the

Judge through the Son (John 5:22; 2 Cor 5:10). John invests the scene with the greatest solemnity. *Earth and sky fled from his presence* (**20:11b**) and *the dead great and small* are *standing before the throne* (**20:12**).

John does not say which *books were opened,* but it seems that they are books in which the names and deeds of all people are written. *The dead were judged* according to the record of *what they had done* (20:12). John is speaking of the eternal judgment against which there is no appeal. He is probably alluding to Daniel 7:10, 'The court was seated; and the books were opened.'

It is sobering to realize that nothing is forgotten or hidden from God: *each person was judged according to what he had done* (**20:13b**). God's judgment always proceeds on the basis of works (Matt 25:41–46; Rom 2:6; 2 Cor 5:10; Heb 4:12–13) as evidence of belief or unbelief in his Son, Jesus Christ (John 3:16; Rom 8:1). Works are an index of the spiritual condition of a person's heart. We are not told whether these books contain either good and evil works or only the latter. Yet the judgment is not a balancing of good works over bad works. Rather, works are seen as unmistakable evidence of the loyalty of the heart; they express belief or unbelief, faithfulness or unfaithfulness. The judgment will reveal whether or not people's loyalties have been with God and the Lamb or with God's enemies. John's theology of faith and its inseparable relation to works is the same as that of Jesus Christ (John 5:29), Paul (Rom 2:6–8) and James (Jas 2), and that is why the record in another book, the *book of life,* seems to be decisive (20:12, 15; 3:5; 13:8; 17:8; 21:27). Those who have their names in the Lamb's 'book of life' will also have records of righteous deeds. The opposite will also be true. The imagery reflects the delicate balance between grace and sin.

The dead are reported to have come from three places: the sea, death and Hades (**20:13a**). The sea represents the place of unburied bodies, while death and Hades represent the reality of dying and the condition entered into at death (1:18; 6:8). Thus all the dead are included. Death and Hades p 1603 are personified and in a vivid image are cast into the *lake of fire* to be permanently destroyed (**20:14;** see 19:20; 20:10).

21:1 Act VII, Scene 3: The new heaven and new earth

A new heaven and a new earth now appear on stage (**21:1**; Isa 65:17; 66:22). Creation is being renewed. As the apocalyptic drama nears its end, all evil has been destroyed (17:1–20:15). Not only do the old earth and heaven pass away, but the sea, which is a symbol of chaos, rebellion and evil, no longer exists.

21:2–8 Act VII, Scene 4: The new Jerusalem

John sees the *new Jerusalem* coming down out of heaven. Jerusalem was an accepted symbol of the people of God. It was a tangible sign of the covenant, the focus of Jewish faith and hope. In the OT it was described as the place where God dwelt (Ps 76:2), and it is the place where our redemption was accomplished. But this Jerusalem is different from the old one in that it is *new* and *holy.* This is no human construction. Its origin is God.

John smoothly combines the traditional images of city and bride, saying that the city is *prepared as a bride beautifully dressed for her husband* (**21:2**). The 'great city' of Satan was depicted as a prostitute, but this city is the complete opposite. It will be the place where God eternally dwells with his people, and where there will be no emotional and physical pain or illness (**21:3–5**).

God speaks directly to his people, declaring that the re-creation of all things is completed (**21:6–7**). The end has arrived through the actions of the one who is *Alpha and Omega* (1:8). All those who are wicked are excluded from the kingdom of God (**21:8**).

21:9–21 Act VII, Scene 5: Measuring the new Jerusalem

It is significant that the angel who now shows John *the bride, the wife of the Lamb,* is identified in the same way as the angel who showed him the 'great prostitute' (**21:9**; 17:1). The prostitute and the beast were described at length, and so is the city that is the bride in order to bring out the contrast between the rival cities of Babylon and the new Jerusalem.

John's model for the city is Ezekiel's vision of the new temple and the new Jerusalem (Ezek 40–48). In both Ezekiel and Revelation, the seer is led by an angel who shows him the new creation. The presence of the glory of God is central. In Ezekiel, 'the land was radiant with his glory' (Ezek 43:2). In John's vision, God's glory is seen in *brilliance … like that of a very precious jewel, like a jasper, clear as crystal* (**21:11**; compare Isa 60:1–2, 19).

In ancient times, a wall was an essential feature of a city (Isa 26:1). The wall of the new Jerusalem is very high and is 144 cubits (two hundred feet or sixty metres) thick, symbolizing the greatness of the city as well as its impregnability against attack by those described in 21:8 and 27 (**21:12a, 17**). (However, it is also possible that it is the height of the wall that is 144 cubits, in which case the walls are tiny compared to the height of the city, indicating that it is so secure that it scarcely needs a wall.)

In his description of the gates, John follows Ezekiel closely (**21:12b–13**; Ezek 48:30–35). The number twelve figures prominently here. There are twelve gates: three in each wall, with one of the names of the tribes of Israel carved on each (21:12). There are twelve foundations to the city wall, each with the name of one of the twelve apostles of Jesus (**21:14**).

Although the city is measured by the angel, the units of measurement are those commonly used by humans (21:17). The city is a cube: *12,000 stadia* [1500 miles / 2200 kilometres] *in length, and as wide and high as it is long* (**21:16**). This figure (twelve times one thousand) reinforces the earlier reference to the twelve tribes of Israel and the twelve apostles. Again we must not take these numbers literally. What they are communicating is simply that this is an immense city, with room for an enormous number of inhabitants (7:9; John 14:2). There will be room for all believers, of all times.

The city is beautiful and precious beyond all imagination, full of gold and jewels (**21:18–21**). But the central image is of the light, the radiance, the glory that is here because of the presence of God in the midst of the city. The great street itself is made of gold so pure that it is as transparent as glass. This is a description in human language of the great majesty that awaits believers—to be in the presence of God for ever.

21:22–27 Act VII, Scene 6: The lamp of the city

The radical newness of this city of God is seen in the fact that it has no temple (**21:22**). Israel knew that God could not be contained in any human building, but in Solomon's prayer of consecration for the original temple he prayed that 'your eyes may be open towards this temple night and day, this place of which you said, "My Name shall be there" ' (1 Kgs 8:29). Ezekiel saw the cloud of glory leave the temple, as a sign that God's presence had left the city and the temple before they were

destroyed (Ezek 10:18–19; 11:23). Ezekiel's vision of the restored Jerusalem includes a new temple, but John's vision does not, for God is its sanctuary (and all its inhabitants are priests—5:10; 20:6).

Just as there is no need of a temple, so there is no need for light. *The city does not need the sun or the moon to shine on it* (**21:23**). God's glory is the illumination for the blessed ones, and God does not depart from the Holy City. The old heaven containing the sun and the moon can be destroyed because it is no long needed.

p 1604 John sees God bringing *the nations* into the holy city (**21:24, 26**). The gates are never closed, because there is no need for defence and because there is no night, the time when city gates were normally closed (**21:25**). Nothing evil, nothing unclean, will be able to contaminate or corrupt the new Jerusalem (**21:27**).

22:1–5 Act VII, Scene 7: The city's source of life

The concluding chapter of Revelation recalls the creation before the fall. But the redemption of the world is not a simple return to the original creation. All of human history stands in between, with the development of civilization, the enormous growth of population, the creation of cities and all the conflicts of human societies. That is why John sees the future as a city, not as a garden of Eden.

The *river of the water of life* and the *tree of life* are now in the midst of the Holy City (**22:1–2**; see Gen 2:9–10). Now, almost at the end of human history, humans may return and legitimately enjoy the blessing from which they were banished. The river and the tree are reminders that life comes from God. The tree of life is said to bear fruit every month and it is specifically said to bear *twelve crops of fruit* (that is, twelve crops in succession, not twelve kinds of fruit—22:2a). As there is neither sun nor moon there is of course no 'month', but John's imagery here shows that there is an abundant supply. The image also suggests that life in the new Jerusalem has characteristics of our earthly life—there is food to be eaten, and there are seasons. *The leaves of the tree* are said to be *for the healing of the nations* (22:2b; Ezek 47:12). *Healing* should not be understood in a literal sense because in the new city there is neither sickness nor sin. But the image expresses the truth that in the new city there is enjoyment of life.

The most revealing characteristic of life in the new Jerusalem is that God's people *will see his face* (**22:4**). Life in God's new kingdom is eternal, for *they will reign forever and ever* (**22:5**). It is not said that they will reign over anyone; therefore it is better to take the term *reign* as a reference to being in the royal presence with God. This scene marks the climax of the whole book, the culmination of the process that began in chapters 2 and 3 with the promises made to 'overcomers'. The throne is right in the midst of the new Jerusalem and the believers are now and for ever in the presence of God.

22:6–21 Epilogue

The book concludes with a series of warnings, exhortations and assurances. There are three major emphases in the conclusion: confirmation of the genuineness of the prophecy (22:6–7, 16, 18–19); the imminence of Jesus' second coming (22:7, 12, 20); the warning against idolatry and the invitation to enter the city (22:11, 15, 17).

The reader is returned to the atmosphere at the beginning of the book. It was Jesus who commanded John to write the letter to be sent to the seven churches (1:17–20). Now that the vision is complete, Jesus blesses those who remain faithful (**22:7**). John then adds his own witness that he has indeed written what he saw and heard (**22:8**). He again falls at the feet of his angelic guide to worship him, only to be told again not to do so (22:8–9; 19:10). God alone is to be worshipped. The angel and John, along with the prophets and all faithful believers, are simply servants. John's response shows the overwhelming authority given to the true Word of God. The angel's response shows that the authority given to the Word must not be transferred to the messenger.

The angel (assuming that this is the *he* who speaks) tells John not to seal the book that he has written (**22:10**). By contrast, Daniel was told to seal up his writings because the time for them had not yet come (Dan 8:26). The book John saw in 5:1–9 was sealed with seven seals. It set out the goal of God's creation and the process by which it would be achieved, and could only be opened by 'the Lamb who was slain' (5:12) after his work of redemption had been accomplished.

Jesus now speaks, declaring he will come bringing this reward, which will result in both blessing and punishment (**22:12**). He applies to himself the same titles that have been used for God (**22:13**; 1:8; 21:6). The final blessing of the book is pronounced upon *those who wash their robes* (**22:14**), that is, those who have been redeemed by Christ's death (7:14). They will be able to enter the city of God and eat of the tree of life, which will give them eternal life. The wicked, however, will remain outside the city and not receive its blessed inheritance (**22:15**). These words of Jesus reinforce the words of the angel he has sent to lead John through the vision (**22:16**). The use of a plural *you* in this verse indicates that it is not John, but the readers, who need this added word of authority.

The final section of Revelation (22:17–21) is not only an ending, but also a beginning. There is an invitation issued by the *Spirit and the bride* (**22:17**). The invitation is to come and drink *the water of life.* The invitation is the same as, or at least includes, an invitation to come to the Lord's Table, for similar words were used by first-century Christians at the end of the Lord's Supper: *Come, Lord Jesus!* (**22:20**). Paul concludes his first letter to the Corinthians in the same way (1 Cor 16:22). Clearly, these letters were intended to be read in the worship service.

Between the invitation (22:17) and the conclusion (22:20–21) is a final warning to take seriously what John has written and not to change the words of the book. The accuracy and authenticity of the work are guaranteed by a curse formula (**22:18–19**). Who is the *I* who says these p 1605 words? Most likely it is John himself. The words parallel the warning given by Jesus in 22:14–15.

John has finished his task. He has faithfully recorded what he has seen and heard in his vision. His words have been authenticated both by the angel and by Jesus himself. Now it is up to those who receive the book to follow its guidance. Will the words be so difficult that some readers will be tempted to tone them down and change them, enabling them to compromise with the powers that be? Difficult as they are, the words are to remain. Those who would change them would be revealing that they are among the unfaithful, and would thus suffer the consequences described in the book.

The final words of Revelation are similar to those in most NT letters: *The grace of the Lord Jesus be with God's people. Amen.*

Onesimus Ngundu

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Further Reading

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